

Consumer forgiveness: A literature review and research agenda

Irem Yoruk¹  | Jen-Hsien Hsu² | Zach W. Y. Lee²

¹College of Business and Economics,
California State University, Los Angeles,
California, USA

²University of Leicester School of Business,
The University of Leicester, Leicester, UK

Correspondence

Irem Yoruk, College of Business and
Economics, California State University, Los
Angeles, 5151 State University Dr, Los
Angeles, CA, 90032, USA.
Email: iyoruk@calstatela.edu

Abstract

Consumer forgiveness represents a compelling phenomenon for marketers, as understanding and leveraging forgiveness allows repairing consumer brand relationships. Marketing scholars began to pay closer attention to consumer forgiveness in the last decade with attempts to better understand and analyze this construct. This literature review on consumer forgiveness seeks to enrich the discourse on this phenomenon through a comprehensive systematic review of 89 articles. Through this literature review, we synthesize the findings of 89 articles to (1) understand how involved agents (e.g., firms/brands, humans, and autonomous technologies) influence the consumer forgiveness process, (2) develop a theoretical integrative framework delineating salient psychological mechanisms of the consumer forgiveness process, and (3) propose a future research agenda on consumer forgiveness.

KEYWORDS

brand transgressions, consumer forgiveness, future research agenda, literature review, negative marketing events, product-harm crises, service failures

1 | INTRODUCTION

Consumer forgiveness is increasingly viewed as a critical mechanism for repairing consumer-brand relationships after negative marketing events such as product-harm crisis, service failures, and brand transgressions (Khamitov et al., 2020). Consumer forgiveness is a significant concept for businesses for its potential as a strategic tool to restore and repair trust and loyalty among customers affected by negative marketing events (Xie & Peng, 2009). As companies face the challenges of maintaining customer satisfaction and loyalty in a turbulent environment, understanding how to effectively facilitate forgiveness has become essential (Kim et al., 2023; Tsarenko & Tojib, 2015). Therefore, the concept of consumer forgiveness has recently garnered significant interest among marketing scholars, particularly due to a rise in negative marketing events and the growing necessity for obtaining forgiveness from consumers.

The idea of forgiveness first appeared in theology research and later has been extensively studied in psychology, where experts have

investigated how forgiving self and others can help heal and repair relationships. In the marketing domain, the interest in comprehending the dynamics of forgiveness is driven by the recognition that consumer forgiveness has profound consequences on the longevity of consumer-brand relationships amid negative marketing events. For example, scholars in service marketing research examine forgiveness as the unique way to mend and maintain the bond between consumers and brands after service failures (Kim & Ho, Tan, et al., 2023).

Although consumer forgiveness is getting increased scholarly attention in the marketing literature, there still lacks a systematic understanding of the consumer forgiveness processes and the resulting implications for marketers and practitioners. Furthermore, the introduction of artificial intelligence (AI) and autonomous technologies into businesses adds another layer of complexity to the consumer forgiveness phenomenon where such technologies either contribute to the wrongdoings and/or play a role in the recovery after related negative marketing events (Agnihotri & Bhattacharya, 2024; Arikan et al., 2023), influencing the consumer forgiveness processes.

Prior research has examined different aspects of forgiveness, such as its antecedents, consequences, and other underlying psychological processes such as mediators and moderators (Kim & Ho, Tan, et al., 2023; Özdemir, 2023). Witnessing the increasing importance of consumer forgiveness in marketing literature, two systematic literature review studies (e.g., Kim & Ho, Tan, et al., 2023; Özdemir, 2023) have been conducted to synthesize the consumer forgiveness literature. In particular, Kim, and Ho, Tan, et al. (2023) have summarized the literature on forgiveness within the context of service failures (without delving into product failure or brand transgression literatures). In parallel, Özdemir (2023) has conducted a systematic overview of the larger consumer forgiveness literature providing a descriptive summary of the literature by year and journal, theoretical background, methodological trends, and thematic issues (e.g., antecedents, consequences, mediators, and moderators). Özdemir (2023) lamented that while the number of research paper on consumer forgiveness is increasing, at least a fourth of the studies “lack the utilization of any theoretical framework when providing the conceptual framework” (Özdemir, 2023, p. 1252). Furthermore, Kim, and Ho, Tan, et al. (2023) called for research that integrates theoretical perspectives into a unique framework to explain consumer forgiveness from different perspectives. We concur with these comments and respond to them with our attempt to develop a systematic understanding of the consumer forgiveness literature (see Table 1). For this purpose, in this paper we employ a deep exploration of a theory-driven integrative framework delineating salient psychological mechanisms of the consumer forgiveness process. We then integrate and synthesize our findings to propose a new framework for consumer forgiveness that is of paramount importance and will steer the future research on consumer forgiveness. In our literature review, we encompass all consumer forgiveness research conducted in the contexts of service failure, product failure and brand transgressions contexts. Additionally, we integrate findings of qualitative research into our synthesis.

Against this backdrop, this systematic literature review aims to (1) understand how involved agents (e.g., firms/brands, humans, and autonomous technologies) influence the consumer forgiveness process, (2) develop a theory-driven integrative framework delineating salient psychological mechanisms of the consumer forgiveness process, and (3) propose future research avenues on consumer forgiveness. This paper not only advances the growing body of knowledge of consumer forgiveness but also aids marketers and

practitioners with guidelines on effectively repairing customer relationships amid negative marketing events.

The paper is structured as follows. The methodology section describes the literature search and identification processes. The analysis and synthesis section provides an in-depth review and synthesis of the theories used in explaining consumer forgiveness, definitions of consumer forgiveness, contexts in which consumer forgiveness has been examined, and mediating and moderating variables that play a role in the consumer forgiveness process. This section serves to identify how involved agents (e.g., firms/brands, humans, and autonomous technologies) influence the consumer forgiveness process and informs the proposed framework. The subsequent results section introduces the proposed integrative framework of consumer forgiveness, where consumer forgiveness is portrayed as a coping process where salient theoretical lenses are consolidated in different stages of the process (e.g., attribution theory and justice theory). Finally, discussion of the implications for research and practice, future research directions, and limitations are provided.

2 | METHODOLOGY

A systematic literature search was undertaken to identify studies investigating consumer forgiveness. A two-stage literature search approach was employed to systematically search for and identify relevant articles. This approach represents a systematic, replicable, and transparent process to minimize bias through conducting comprehensive literature searches of published studies and providing an audit trail of the procedures, decisions, and conclusions from reviewers (Tranfield et al., 2003). Figure 1 illustrates the sequence of the literature search and identification processes.

In the first stage, literature searches were conducted to identify journal articles that examined forgiveness in negative marketing events. To identify peer-reviewed journal articles, we began by conducting a title search using *keyword combinations* related to forgiveness and negative marketing events, including *forgiv* AND firm, company, corporate, brand, product, service, consumer, customer, sales, sell*, purchas*, shop*, buy*, marketing, advertis*, AI, chatbot, robot*.

Pertinent electronic databases were consulted, including *Scopus, APA PsycArticles, APA PsylInfo, Business Source Premier, Library, and Information Science & Technology Abstracts*. We did not impose any restrictions on the research timeframe to capture all consumer

TABLE 1 Positioning of this paper.

Studies	Context	Nature of the literature review	Number of papers analyzed
Kim et al. (2023)	Service failures	Summary of literature	102
Özdemir (2023)	Service failures, product-harm crises, and brand transgressions	Summary of literature	77
This paper	Service failures, product-harm crises, and brand transgressions	Synthesis of the consumer forgiveness process informed by theories, mediating and moderating variables	89

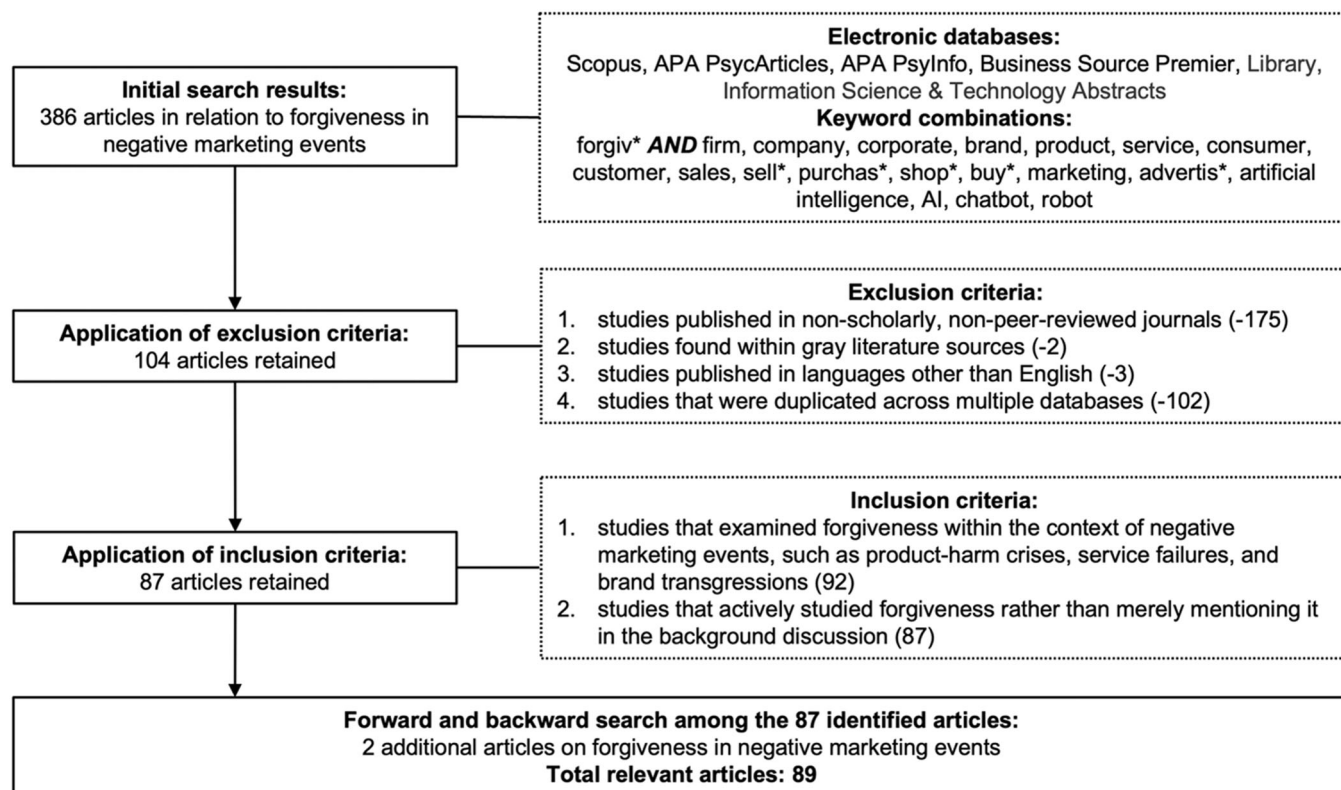


FIGURE 1 Literature search and identification processes.

forgiveness studies since its first publication. Gray literature, including theses, dissertations, conference papers and proceedings, research reports, government documents, and technical notes, was intentionally excluded for the following two reasons. First, the retrieval of gray literature can present challenges, potentially impeding the replication of prior research endeavors. Second, conference papers could be published later in journals, leading to unnecessary duplication of the same studies. Consequently, our literature search was primarily centered on the identification of peer-reviewed journal articles that are readily accessible to the academic community and to avoid unnecessary duplication of identified articles. An update on the literature search was conducted in April 2024 to identify recent publications on forgiveness in negative marketing events. Taken together, the literature search initially identified 386 studies.

In the second stage, following similar literature review studies in business literature (Chan et al., 2017), we applied *exclusion* and *inclusion* criteria to the initial pool of studies. This step aimed to eliminate studies that did not directly address our initial research inquiries and to ensure that only pertinent studies were retained for subsequent analyses. Specifically, we refined our initial sample to comprise studies in which forgiveness was either a prominent theme or the central focus of the investigation. This strategic approach to literature selection enabled us to concentrate on the core phenomenon under investigation while avoiding the inclusion of an unwieldy number of articles with limited relevance.

The four exclusion criteria encompassed: studies published in nonscholarly, nonpeer-reviewed journals (-175); studies found within gray literature sources (-2); studies published in languages other than English (-3); and studies that were duplicated across multiple databases (-102). In contrast, the two inclusion criteria entailed: studies that examined forgiveness within the context of negative marketing events, such as product-harm crises, service failures, and brand transgressions (83); and studies that actively studied forgiveness rather than merely mentioning it in the background discussion (78).

Subsequently, we conducted a comprehensive backward search, scrutinizing the references and bibliographies of the articles to identify additional relevant prior publications (Webster & Watson, 2002). Additionally, we conducted a forward search by utilizing the Web of Science, the electronic counterpart of the Social Science Citation Index, to identify articles that cited the key articles identified above. This process yielded an additional 2 studies, resulting in a total of 89 articles for subsequent review and analysis.

3 | ANALYSES AND SYNTHESIS

In this section, we synthesize the literature and present (1) the core theories applied in the literature, (2) conceptualizations of consumer forgiveness, (3) the contexts in which consumer forgiveness is examined, and (4) how involved agents (e.g., firms/brands, humans, and

autonomous technologies) influence the consumer forgiveness processes as well as the role of mediators and moderators used in them. This synthesis lays the ground for our proposed integrative framework of consumer forgiveness which is presented in the results section.

3.1 | Theories

The primary research objective of this literature review study is to develop a theory-driven integrative framework delineating salient psychological mechanisms of the consumer forgiveness process. For this purpose, we review the consumer forgiveness literature and identify the predominant theoretical frameworks used to examine the consumer forgiveness process. Table 2 summarizes the theories adopted in the consumer forgiveness literature and their frequencies of use. As seen in Table 2, the most frequently used theories to understand consumer forgiveness behavior have been (1) attribution theory, (2) coping theory, and (3) justice theory. In this paper we focus on the three most frequently used theories and work with an amalgamation of them to explain consumer forgiveness. Moreover, coping theory, attribution theory, and justice theory demonstrate complementariness to each other in depicting a holistic view of the consumer forgiveness process. We build primarily on these three groups of theories in constructing an integrative framework of consumer forgiveness as a coping process where the attributions of the causes of negative marketing events and the perceived justices in the recovery efforts play a key role in influencing consumer forgiveness and related outcomes. Whenever appropriate, concepts identified from other theoretical perspectives and relevant to the consumer forgiveness coping process are incorporated into the integrative framework to provide a comprehensive understanding of the phenomenon.

3.1.1 | Coping theory

Coping theory offers a valuable framework for understanding how individuals navigate stressful, adverse, and challenging situations. It posits that individuals' perceptions and appraisals of stressors are critical in determining their coping responses (Lazarus & Folkman, 1984). The coping process is fundamentally based on two key appraisals: primary appraisal, which involves assessing whether a situation poses a threat, challenge, or harm, and secondary appraisal, which involves evaluating the resources available to manage the situation.

In the context of consumer forgiveness, coping theory is particularly relevant for explaining how individuals respond to negative marketing events and has been extensively adopted in the literature (Bath & Bawa, 2020; Harrison-Walker, 2019; Kaur et al., 2022; Lin & Chou, 2022; Riaz & Khan, 2016; Salagrama et al., 2021; Tsarenko & Rooslani Tojib, 2011; Yang & Hu, 2021; Zourrig et al., 2009). During the primary appraisal stage, consumers assess

the negative marketing event to determine its significance, specifically whether it threatens their sense of fairness or harms their relationship with the brand. This appraisal is not merely transactional but is also deeply emotional, triggering a range of negative emotions such as disappointment, anger, and betrayal. The disruption to the transactional exchange and the resulting emotional distress create conditions in which consumers may consider forgiveness as a coping mechanism.

The secondary appraisal stage involves an evaluation of the resources available to cope with the situation. Consumers assess whether they possess sufficient emotional resilience, prior experience, or social support to manage the disruption and accompanying negative emotions. If they perceive that they have adequate resources to address these challenges, they may choose to engage in forgiveness as a deliberate coping strategy. Additionally, if consumers perceive that the offending party has made significant reparative efforts and demonstrated sincere remorse, they are more inclined to forgive. Such forgiveness helps reestablish relational balance and allows consumers to continue engaging in the transactional relationship without the burden of unresolved negative feelings (Tsarenko & Rooslani Tojib, 2011; Tsarenko & Tojib, 2012).

Consumer forgiveness is not limited to specific types of negative marketing events, such as product-harm crises, service failures, or brand transgressions. Each of these events may be perceived by consumers as either a challenge or a harm, thereby triggering the primary appraisal process. For example, product-harm crises may pose a direct threat to consumers' health and safety, resulting in significant emotional distress. Service failures may violate consumers' expectations of reliability and trustworthiness, leading to feelings of frustration and disappointment. Brand transgressions, such as ethical breaches or misleading advertising, may damage consumers' sense of integrity and fairness, causing feelings of betrayal and anger. Despite the variations in the nature of these events, they all challenge consumers' expectations and can be perceived as harmful to their physical, emotional, or psychological well-being. These perceived challenges or harms *activate* the coping process, prompting consumers to engage in primary and secondary appraisals to manage their emotional responses and decide on appropriate actions as an individual.

3.1.2 | Attribution theory

Attribution theory suggests individuals make sense of events and behaviors by attributing causes to their occurrences (Kelley, 1973). Individuals can attribute the cause of events or behaviors to either internal (personal) or external (situational) factors. Such attributions are based on the observed covariation of a cause with an effect across time, place, and different situations. Attribution theory represents another valuable lens for understanding forgiveness and consumer responses to negative marketing events and has been utilized in consumer forgiveness literature. Such that, consumers

TABLE 2 A summary of theories adopted in the consumer forgiveness studies.

Theories	Studies adopting the theories	Frequency
Attribution theory	Arikan et al. (2023); Aw & Labrecque (2023); Casey et al. (2024); Chen et al. (2022a); 2022c; Cheng (2023); Shimul et al. (2022); Siamagka (2023); Sinha & Lu (2016); Suri et al. (2019)	10
Cognitive appraisal theory	Bath & Bawa (2020); Harrison-Walker (2019); Kaur et al. (2022); Lin & Chou (2022); Riaz & Khan (2016); Salagrama et al. (2021); Tsarenko & Rooslani Tojib (2011); Yang & Hu (2021); Zourrig et al. (2009)	9
Justice theory	Babin et al. (2021); Casidy & Shin (2015); Çelik et al., 2024; Muhammad & Mokhtar (2017); Shin et al. (2018); Wei et al. (2020); Xie & Peng (2009); Zhi & Ha (2024)	8
Personality trait perspective	Alnawas et al. (2023); Siamagka (2023); Tsarenko & Tojib (2012)	3
Self-construal theory	Aw et al. (2022); Luo et al. (2024); Sinha & Lu (2016)	3
Social exchange theory	Shimul et al. (2024); Wei et al. (2020); Xie & Peng (2009)	3
Stimuli-organism-response framework	Kim & Kinoshita (2023); Sahaf & Fazili (2024); Wei et al. (2022)	3
Construal level theory	Çelik et al., 2024; Rathee et al. (2022)	2
Sense making theory	Muhammad & Gul-E-Rana (2020); Rasouli et al. (2022)	2
Signaling theory	Ali et al. (2023); Flacandji et al. (2023)	2
Adaptation-level theory	Zhi & Ha (2024)	1
Affect infusion theory	Umar & Saleem (2022)	1
Attachment theory	Shimul et al. (2024)	1
Cognitive dissonance theory	Ge et al. (2023)	1
Complexity theory	Ali et al. (2023)	1
Computers are social actors theory	Agnihotri & Bhattacharya (2024)	1
Cultural tightness-looseness theory	Ge et al. (2023)	1
Emotional contagion theory	Umar & Saleem (2022)	1
Emotion regulation theory	Mednini & Damak Turki (2024)	1
Face negotiation theory	Bath & Bawa (2020)	1
Functionalist framework of emotion	Septianto et al. (2020)	1
Moral foundation theory	Davvetas et al. (2024)	1
Parasocial interaction theory	Aw & Labrecque (2023)	1
Regulatory focus theory	Atav et al. (2021)	1
Self-determination theory	Tsarenko et al. (2019)	1
Service recovery paradox	Dlodlo (2017)	1
Social capital theory	Muhammad & Gul-e-Rana (2019)	1
Social cognition theory	Luo et al. (2024)	1
Social identity threats theory	Davvetas et al. (2024)	1
Social response theory	Guan & Sun (2023)	1

Note: Sorted first by the frequency of adoption followed by the alphabetical order of theory names.

attribute the causes of negative events to factors such as product quality, company negligence, or external factors (e.g., uncontrollable circumstances), which later impact consumers' attitudes and behaviors (Weiner, 1985, 2000). Specifically, individuals blame (and forgive) offenders based on their attributions of intent (e.g., whether the harm was intentional or accidental), stability (e.g., whether the behavior is

likely to reoccur), and controllability (e.g., whether the transgressor had control over the situation) (Weiner, 2000). As we will explain further in the next section, when individuals attribute the harm to external, unstable, and uncontrollable factors, they process forgiveness differently than when they attribute harm to internal, stable and controllable factors.

3.1.3 | Justice theory

Justice theory is a branch of philosophy that explores the concept of justice and how it can be applied to create a fair and equitable society. It aims to explain how individuals perceive justice and provide principles for determining what is just or unjust in different contexts (Greenberg, 1990). Justice is typically defined as the quality of being fair, reasonable, and impartial (Greenberg, 1990). The effect of perceived justice has been highlighted to have crucial roles specifically in the recovery stage after negative marketing events (the secondary appraisal) and justice is examined to influence consumer forgiveness outcomes. Commonly, consumers need the restoration of justice after transgressions. When individuals perceive that the transgressors' actions as unfair or unjust (e.g., due to intent or negligence), they are less inclined to forgive (Babin et al., 2021). Interactional justice, distributive justice, and procedural justice are three subdimensions of justice theory. Interactional justice focuses on whether people perceive the behavior of others, such as transgressors, as respectful, polite, and/or considerate. Consumers are more likely to forgive when they perceive that the wrongdoers treat them with respect, empathy, and honesty in recovery processes. In situations where the interaction is characterized by rudeness, insensitivity, or deception, forgiveness is less likely. Distributive justice is linked to consumers' perceptions of whether the wrongdoers have provided adequate compensation or restitution. When consumers perceive that the compensation for losses has been fair, they are more inclined to forgive (Wei et al., 2020). Finally, procedural justice is related to the processes employed by the wrongdoers in addressing negative events. When consumers perceive that the procedures for addressing the event are fair, open, and give them a voice, they are more likely to forgive (Muhammad & Mokhtar, 2017). Procedural injustice, such as secretive decision-making or a lack of opportunity for consumers to express their grievances, hinders forgiveness.

To conclude, coping, attribution, and justice theories have been extensively adopted in prior studies to explain consumer forgiveness amidst negative marketing events and provide solid theoretical foundations for developing the integrative framework of consumer forgiveness. Following the literature, we propose consumer forgiveness as a coping process where causal attributions of wrongdoings play a key role in primary appraisal and perceptions of justice shape the forgiving responses in secondary appraisal.

3.2 | Consumer forgiveness conceptualization

Marketing scholars draw upon various streams of research in psychology, particularly intrapersonal and interpersonal forgiveness, to conceptualize consumer forgiveness. This cross-disciplinary borrowing has resulted in diverse definitions of consumer forgiveness within marketing literature. Table 3 summarizes the most commonly adopted consumer forgiveness definitions. However, this fragmented literature has not yielded a distinct, agreed-upon definition of

consumer forgiveness in marketing. Consequently, scholars have adopted an array of scales to measure this construct, reflecting the multidimensionality of forgiveness (see Appendix A). The lack of consensus on the definition and suitable measurement scales for consumer forgiveness poses a critical challenge in comprehending its role in consumer-brand relationships. Therefore, we aim to provide a thorough understanding of this consumer forgiveness concept in this section.

Research have explored motivational, emotional, cognitive, and behavioral components of consumer forgiveness (Babin et al., 2021; McCullough et al., 1998; Worthington & Scherer, 2004). Initial research depicted forgiveness purely as a motivational concept, where individuals who are willing to forgive, reduced their motivation for retaliation and estrangement, maintained conciliation, and fostered goodwill toward the offender (McCullough et al., 1997). As research expanded, McCullough et al. (1998) and Enright et al. (1998) proposed that besides motivation, there are emotional and cognitive components of forgiveness. The emotional component of forgiveness refers to the regulation of individuals' internal affective responses to a transgression and involves a deliberate process of replacing negative emotions with positive ones (Enright et al., 1998; Joireman et al., 2016; Strelan & Covic, 2006; Worthington & Scherer, 2004). The cognitive component of forgiveness refers to the extent to which the consumer attributes certain blame to the transgressor (Hall & Fincham, 2005; Hook et al., 2009). Lastly, it has been proposed that there is also a behavioral component to forgiveness. The behavioral component of forgiveness includes reducing rumination, or harmful behavior towards the transgressor and leads to a person behaving toward the transgressor in the same manner before the transgression (Worthington & Scherer, 2004). A summary of most adopted definitions of consumer forgiveness is provided in Table 3.

Marketing scholars largely adopted the intrapersonal forgiveness definitions from the psychology literature to explain consumer forgiveness, with the exception of two studies that expanded these definitions to take the transactional nature of market exchanges into consideration. Notably, Tsarenko and Tojib (2015) advanced our understanding of consumer forgiveness within the marketing context via anchoring their study on an affective definition of forgiveness from the work of Enright et al. (1998) while addressing the affective differences between intrapersonal forgiveness and consumer forgiveness. Enright et al. (1998, p. 46) define forgiveness as "a willingness to abandon one's right to resentment, negative judgment, and indifferent behavior towards one who unjustly hurt us, while fostering the undeserved qualities of compassion, generosity, and even love towards him or her." This definition focuses on the emotional transformation of the individual, where both negative emotions (like resentment) are released, and positive emotions (like compassion and love) are fostered. Tsarenko and Tojib (2015) while adopting the emotional aspects of forgiveness (e.g., the abandonment of resentment), recognize that the second limb of Enright et al. (1998)'s definition—fostering positive emotions like love and compassion—might not be fully applicable in a consumer context. They argue that love and compassion are less likely to arise in commercial

TABLE 3 A summary of most commonly adopted definitions of consumer forgiveness.

Orientation	Author	Definitions	Marketing studies that adopted the definition
Motivational	McCullough et al. (1997)	Forgiving is a motivational transformation that inclines people to inhibit relationship-destructive responses and to behave constructively toward someone who has behaved destructively toward them.	-
Affective	Baumeister et al. (1998)	Forgiveness is often described as a deliberate process by which consumers decide to forgive or not, reduce their emotional defensiveness, and replace their negative emotions and behaviors such as retaliation and alienation with positive ones.	For example, Davvetas et al. (2024); Noor et al. (2023); Rathee et al. (2022); Tsarenko & Tojib (2015); Wei & Ran (2019)
Behavioral and Affective	McCullough & Hoyt (2002)	Forgiveness behaviors are transformations that decrease revenge and avoidance and increase benevolence toward the offender.	For example, Aw & Labrecque (2023); Casey et al. (2024); Xie & Peng (2009)
	Worthington & Scherer (2004)	A forgiving person tries to behave toward the transgressor in the same manner before the transgression, reflecting the victim's decrease in negative emotions that influences his or her reactions to the transgressor.	
Affective and Cognitive	Hall & Fincham (2005); Hook et al. (2009)	Forgiveness is a complex process, and its formation usually involves affective and cognitive paths. For example, when individuals forgive others, there are two types of situations: affective forgiveness, which refers to an empathic response to the offender from the offender's perspective, and decisional forgiveness, which refers to a judgment of responsibility for the offending event from the perspective of the offending event.	-
Motivational, Emotional, and Behavioral	McCullough et al. (1998)	Forgiveness is a multifaceted concept that involves motivational, emotional, and behavioral processes, such as readiness to pardon, overlook, or reconcile with a brand following disappointing experiences.	For example, Ran et al. (2016); Sinha & Lu (2016)
Behavioral, Affective, and Cognitive	McCullough & Worthington (2001)	Forgiveness occurs in the context of an individual's perception that the action or actions of another person were noxious, harmful, immoral, or unjust. These perceptions typically elicit emotional responses (e.g., anger or fear), motivational responses (e.g., desires to avoid the transgressor or harm the transgressor in kind), cognitive responses (e.g., hostility toward or loss of respect or esteem for the transgressor), or behavioral responses (e.g., avoidance or aggression) that would promote the deterioration of good will toward the offender and social harmony. By forgiving, these negative emotional, motivational, cognitive, or behavioral responses are modulated, so that more prosocial and harmonious interpersonal relations can possibly be resumed.	-

relationships, where consumers are driven by transactions rather than deeply emotional connections. As such, consumers might forgive a brand for pragmatic, outcome-driven reasons, such as the desire to continue benefiting from the brand's products or services, rather than from a place of affection or emotional connection as seen in personal relationships. Thus, they propose that, in a marketing context, consumer forgiveness is closely linked to behavioral outcomes, such as repurchase intentions and brand loyalty rather than brand love.

Furthermore, Xie and Peng (2009) incorporate behavioral responses of consumers and the transactional nature of marketing into the definition of consumer forgiveness. Xie and Peng (2009) anchor their understanding and definition of forgiveness primarily on existing definitions from philosophy, theology, and social science but draw heavily from the relationship perspective outlined by Finkel et al. (2002). Finkel et al. (2002) base their forgiveness definition on the definition of Enright et al. as well; however, they embed affective responses and behavioral tendencies that manifest in the victim's

interaction with the perpetrator as a part of forgiveness processes. Finkel et al. (2002) define interpersonal forgiveness as the victim's resumption of pre-betrayal behavioral tendencies, where the victim foregoes vengeance and other destructive interaction patterns in favor of more constructive, positive behaviors. Modifying this approach that forgiveness has emotional and behavioral components, Xie and Peng (2009) adopt a relationship-oriented view of forgiveness, defining it as "consumers' willingness to give up retaliation, alienation, and other destructive behaviors, and to respond in constructive ways after an organizational violation of trust and related recovery efforts" Xie and Peng (2009, p. 578). This perspective sees forgiveness as a critical part of restoring harmony after a transgression, emphasizing both affective and behavioral dimensions of forgiveness, and it sets the forgiveness context as consumer-firm exchanges.

Researchers have also conceded that consumer forgiveness should be treated as a process - a sequence of events involved in the dynamic relationship between two players, consumer and brand -, rather than one single encounter between players (Khamitov et al., 2020; Kim & Ho, Tan, et al., 2023; Van Vaerenbergh et al., 2019). However, research on the detailed steps of the forgiveness process is limited. Service researchers have addressed the multiple-stage nature of consumer forgiveness in a primitive manner and within the service failure and recovery context. For instance, Kim, and Ho, Tan, et al. (2023) proposed the consumer forgiveness journey encompasses three stages sequentially: (1) pretransgression stage, (2) transgression stage, and (3) recovery stage. Similarly, Khamitov et al. (2020) have characterized the consumer forgiveness stages from a sequential perspective as follows: (1) pre-recovery phase, (2) recovery phase and (3) post-recovery phase stage (Khamitov et al., 2020; Van Vaerenbergh et al., 2019). In sum, understanding of what the multiple stages of the consumer forgiveness journey entails is limited (Kim & Ho, Tan, et al., 2023; Van Vaerenbergh et al., 2019).

3.3 | Contexts

Consumer forgiveness has been researched in the following contexts of negative marketing events: service failures (59 out of 89 papers), brand transgressions (13 out of 89 papers), and product-harm crises (8 out of 89 papers). Service failures refer to a situation where service performance fails to meet consumer's expectations (Smith et al., 1999). Brand transgressions are characterized as violations of the implicit or explicit rules and norms concerning consumer-brand relationship performance and evaluation (Aaker et al., 2004). Product-harm crises refer to occasions where defective or dangerous products lead to widespread public concern and negative publicity (Dawar & Pillutla, 2000).

Within the service failure context, three sub-contexts have emerged: human-human interactions, human-brand interactions, and human-autonomous agent interactions. It is interesting to observe that recent studies started examining service recovery effectiveness

withing human-autonomous agent interactions. For example, Cheng (2023) examines how the service robots' level of anthropomorphism influenced consumers' attributional process and then forgiveness of the concerned service failures; similarly, Arikan et al. (2023) identify the impacts of human-likeness and humanness on responsibility attribution processes and the resulting effects on consumer forgiveness. Leveraging the computers are social actors' theory, Agnihotri and Bhattacharya (2024) study how the traits of AI-based chatbots led to higher level of perceived trustworthy on them and thus higher likelihood of consumer forgiveness. Lastly, Guan and Sun (2023) find that high empathic response from chatbots increased consumer forgiveness intention during service remediation.

To conclude, compared with service failures, the consumer forgiveness journey following brand transgressions and product-harm crises remains significantly underexplored compared to the extensive research dedicated to forgiveness in the service failures context. This disparity in scholarly attention poses a crucial gap in understanding the complexities of consumer responses to brand transgressions and product-harm crises, warranting a dire need for more comprehensive studies in these domains. Besides, in the service failures context, the involvement with nonhuman and autonomous agents have added another layer of complexity to the consumer forgiveness journey as they have been shown above to both influence the consumer attribution of the causes of wrongdoers and play a key role in facilitating forgiveness in the recovery stage. It warrants further research into the multifaceted impacts of nonhuman and autonomous agents in the consumer forgiveness in the service failures contexts and its possibility of extending to product-harm crises and brand transgressions domains.

3.4 | Characteristics

We first developed an integrative framework that consolidates the key variables of consumer forgiveness, as illustrated in Figure 2. This framework organizes the variables in the consumer forgiveness literature into five major categories: consumer forgiveness, antecedents, mediators, moderators, and outcomes. It serves as the foundation for the subsequent Consumer Forgiveness as a Coping Process Framework, depicted in Figure 3. Our extended framework goes beyond a descriptive categorization of variables by incorporating theoretical explanations and the dynamic processes of consumer forgiveness. Specifically, it draws upon the three most salient theoretical perspectives in the consumer forgiveness literature: coping theory, attribution theory, and justice theory. Together, these provide a theory-driven model that explains how consumers cognitively and emotionally navigate forgiveness after negative marketing events.

The consumer forgiveness as a coping process framework underscores the key stages of forgiveness: stimuli, primary appraisal, secondary appraisal, and the coping strategies they employ to process the events and ultimately arrive at forgiveness or nonforgiveness. While the initial integrative framework offers a holistic overview of the key variables involved in consumer forgiveness, the

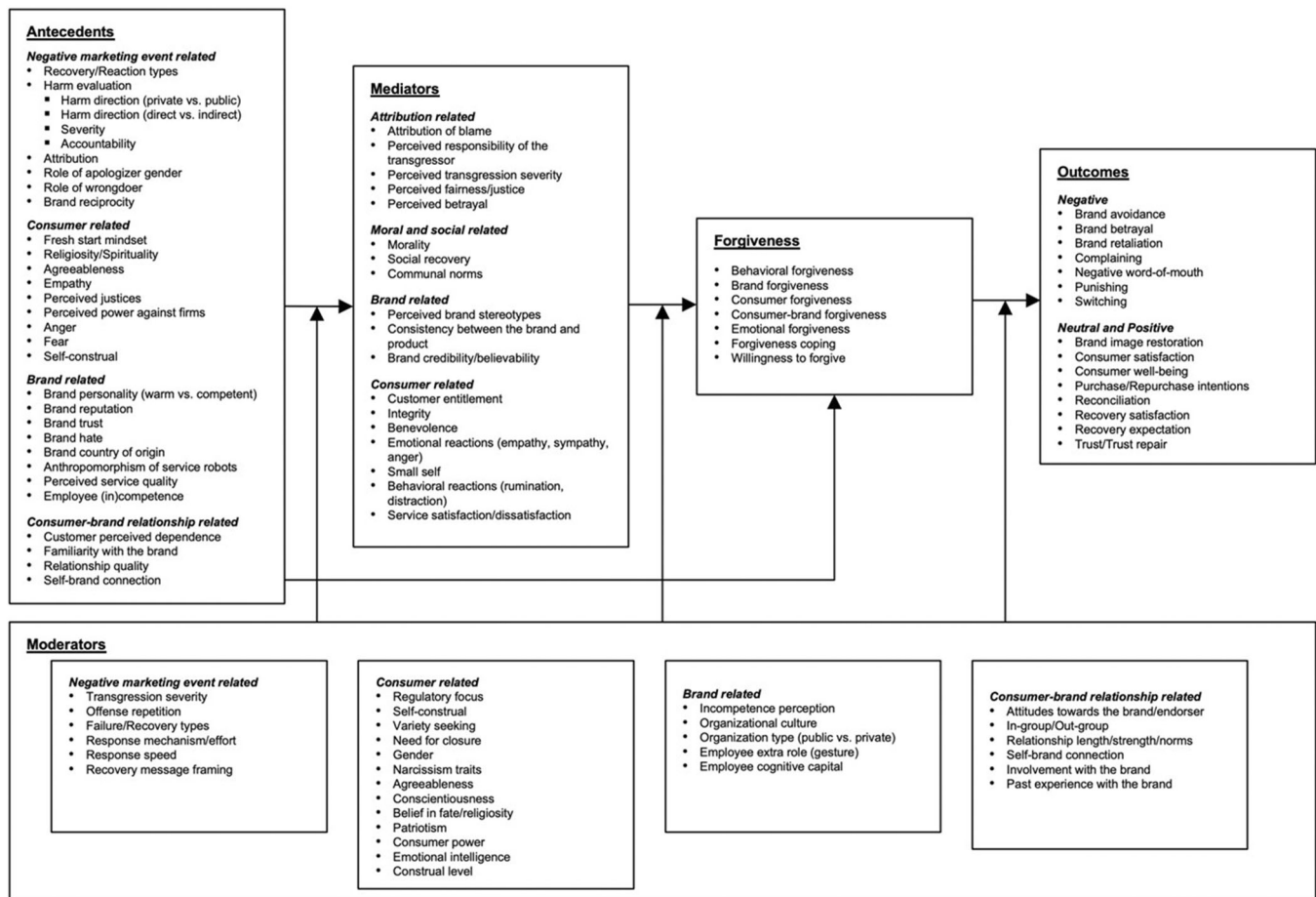


FIGURE 2 An integrative framework of consumer forgiveness variables.

Consumer Forgiveness as a Coping Process Framework provides a more nuanced understanding of the psychological mechanisms and theoretical underpinnings that drive the forgiveness process. This dual approach enables a comprehensive analysis of consumer forgiveness literature, moving from the identification of relevant variables to an exploration of how consumers cognitively and emotionally respond to negative marketing events and navigate the process of forgiveness.

3.4.1 | Mediating mechanisms and related variables

We define mediating variables as the key cognitive, emotional, and motivational components consumers experience in the consumer forgiveness process. This yields the identification of 21 unique mediators from 32 quantitative studies in the literature. We further classify these mediators based on different stages of coping theory and appraisal theory. As such, we categorize mediating variables into three clusters: the primary appraisal stage, the secondary appraisal stage, and emotions. Lastly, we consolidate our insights with the qualitative findings in the literature to provide a holistic view of the mediating variables in the consumer forgiveness process.

3.4.1.1 | Mediating variables at the primary appraisal stage

Informed by coping theory, the primary appraisal stage captures the process during which consumers analyze the responsibility of the transgressing brand and determine the harm impact on themselves (Lazarus & Folkman, 1984). Perceived severity of the negative marketing event is the most adopted mediating variable in the literature (e.g., Fetscherin & Sampedro, 2019; Kaur et al., 2022; Tsarenko et al., 2019). The relationship between perceived severity and consumer forgiveness is shown to be negative across studies, meaning the more severe a transgression is perceived, the less likely consumer forgiveness is to occur.

Empirical studies also highlight distinct determinants of perceived severity within this stage, which can be grouped into two categories: *harm analysis* and *harm evaluation*, based on their theoretical grounding. In the harm analysis category, various attribution-related variables have been identified across different studies, including responsibility attribution (Cheng, 2023; Zourrig et al., 2015), perceived controllability (Lin & Chou, 2022; Salagrama et al., 2021), stability (Lin & Chou, 2022; Salagrama et al., 2021), and intent (Harrison-Walker, 2022). These variables, grounded in attribution theory (Weiner, 1985), help explain how consumers assign responsibility to the transgressing brand. The relationships between these variables and consumer forgiveness are negative across studies.

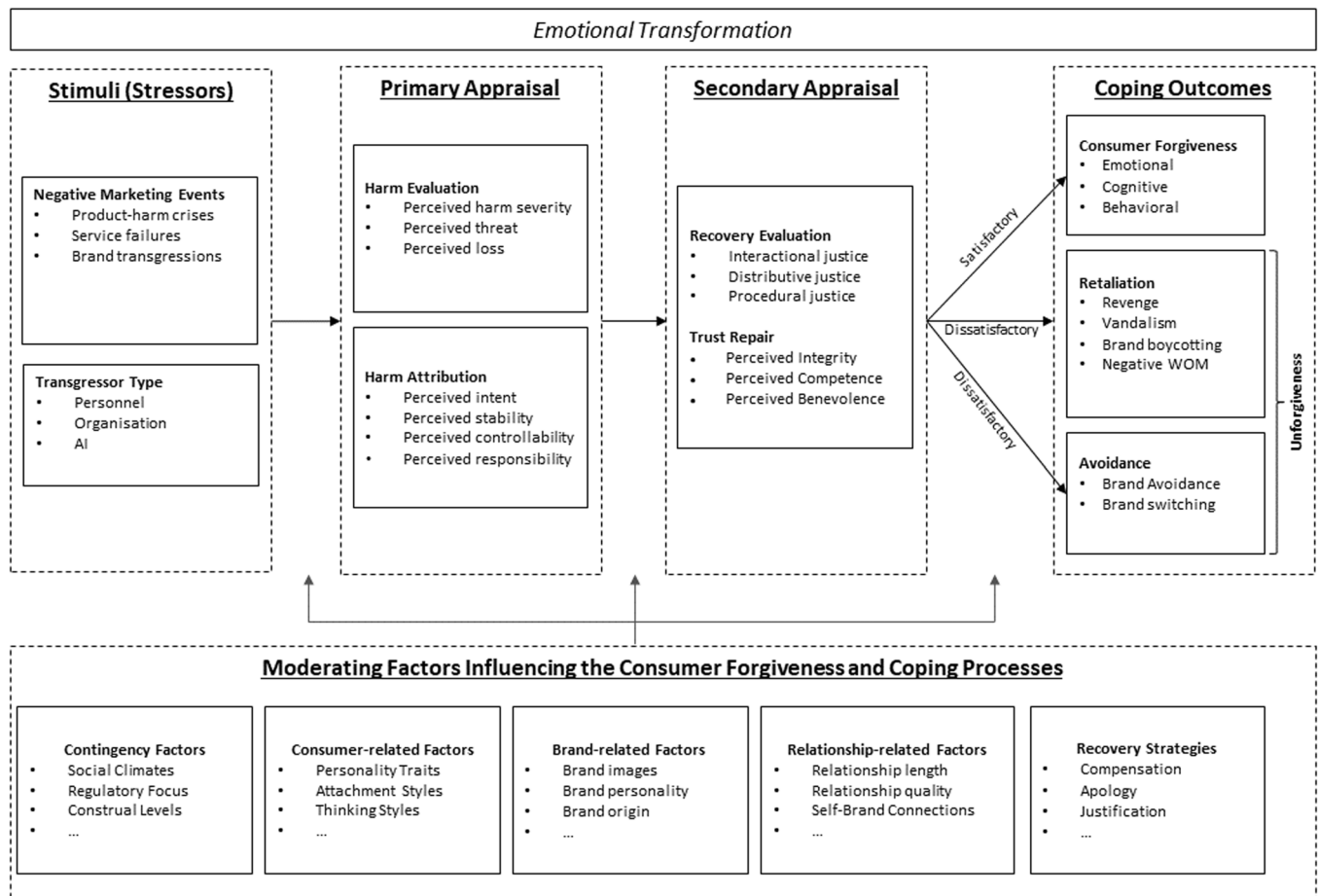


FIGURE 3 The integrative framework of consumer forgiveness as a coping process.

In the harm evaluation category, variables such as perceived threat (Davvetas et al., 2024), perceived harm (Zourrig et al., 2015), and (negative) moral evaluation (Davvetas et al., 2024; Li et al., 2022; Rathee et al., 2022) are identified. These variables are informed by cognitive appraisal theory (Lazarus & Folkman, 1984), which explains how consumers assess the personal impact of the transgression. Similar to harm analysis, these variables exhibit negative relationships with consumer forgiveness across these studies.

3.4.1.2 | Mediating variables at the secondary appraisal stage

Informed by coping theory, the secondary appraisal stage captures how consumers evaluate a brand's recovery attempt and assess whether sufficient resources are offered to facilitate the coping process (Lazarus & Folkman, 1984). We identify five core mediating variables in the literature, which can be grouped into two categories: *recovery evaluation* and *trust recovery*, based on their theoretical grounding. In the recovery evaluation category, the key variables include perceived distributive justice, perceived interactional justice, and perceived procedural justice (Muhammad & Gul-E-Rana, 2020; Muhammad & Mokhtar, 2017; Septianto et al., 2020; Siamagka, 2023). These mediators, grounded in the justice theory (Greenberg, 1990), capture the extent to which consumers perceive justice to be

restored. Empirical evidence indicates a positive relationship between these three variables and consumer forgiveness. In the trust recovery category, the key variables identified are perceived benevolence, perceived competence, and perceived integrity (Agnihotri & Bhattacharya, 2024; Xie & Peng, 2009). These variables are informed by the model of organizational trust (Mayer et al., 1995) and positively correlated with consumer forgiveness in the literature.

3.4.1.3 | Emotion-Based mediating variables

The consumer forgiveness process involves removing, or at least attenuating the negative emotional states triggered by a negative marketing event (Worthington & Scherer, 2004). On the one hand, the emotions elicited by the event influence how consumers engage in the two stages of cognitive appraisal; on the other, the cognitive outcomes from the appraisal further shape consumers' emotional state throughout the forgiveness process. According to coping theory and the forgiveness literature, consumers complete the two stages of appraisal only when they successfully reduce the intensity of the triggered emotions (Folkman et al., 1986). Consumer forgiveness emerges as a coping option when the negative emotions are largely transformed into positive ones, such as empathy and sympathy, during the appraisal process (McCullough et al., 1997; Worthington & Scherer, 2004).

Due to this rationale, we categorize emotions as a distinct cluster of mediating variables. Current research has examined five emotions involved in this complex emotional transformation process: anger (Atav et al., 2021; Riaz & Khan, 2016), fear (Ran et al., 2016), empathy (Chen et al., 2022b; Suri et al., 2019), sympathy (Atav et al., 2021; Zourrig et al., 2015), and compassion (Riaz & Khan, 2016). As expected, positive emotions were positively correlated with consumer forgiveness, while negative emotions were negatively correlated, as shown in these studies. However, we argue that the existing literature has not yet captured the full range of emotions consumers may experience, given the complexity of the forgiveness process. More critically, the connection between consumer emotions and the two appraisal stages has yet to be systematically investigated, despite the inseparable nature of these components in the coping process (Lazarus & Folkman, 1984).

3.4.1.4 | Further synthesis with the qualitative findings

We identify six qualitative studies in the literature. Four of which complement quantitative investigations into harm evaluation (Chong & Ahmed, 2018), harm analysis (Casey et al., 2024), and emotional transformation processes (Mednini & Damak Turki, 2024; Yagil & Luria, 2016). However, insights from the remaining two studies suggest an important yet underexplored research avenue: the role of self-concept maintenance in consumer forgiveness. Specifically, Finsterwalder et al. (2017) highlight self-interest and self-protection as pivotal drivers of consumer forgiveness, suggesting that consumer forgiveness can be motivated by personal interests, such as maintaining parasocial relationships with celebrities or protecting one's self-concept or extended self. Similarly, Tsarenko et al. (2019) argue that consumer forgiveness can also stem from internal motivations rather than sheerly relying solely on recovery efforts from the brand. Through their interviews, they distinguish two additional self-concept maintenance-related reasons for forgiveness: an act of self-healing and grace. In summary, these two studies indicate that consumer forgiveness involves more than just coping with the harm/loss (e.g., justice restoration and trust recovery) caused by negative events; self-concept maintenance can also play a significant role in the process. Table 4 presents a summary of all the mediation variables analyzed in the literature.

3.4.2 | Moderating mechanisms and related variables

We conceptualize moderating variables as the key determinants that can intervene in the forgiveness process. This leads to the identification of 47 unique mediators from 39 quantitative studies in the literature. We organize these moderation effects into two themes, *transgression tolerance* and *effective recovery*, based on whether recovery was included in the research designs. Finally, we summarize the moderation variables by themes and characteristics in line with their impacts on consumer forgiveness and integrate our insights with the qualitative findings in the literature.

3.4.2.1 | Theme 1: Transgression tolerance

In this theme, we include all the empirical studies that did not include an intervention of recovery in their research design. In these studies, researchers aim to investigate the factors that consumers attribute to negative marketing events as less severe and make them more forgiving. We identify 32 moderation variables from 23 studies. Among these variables, 17 are consumer-related, 9 are relationship-related, and 6 are brand-related.

The consumer-related variables in this theme are tested under their potential influence on (1) increasing/decreasing the chance of perspective-taking and (2) reducing the use of affective information in the thinking process. Concerning the likelihood of perspective-taking, empirical studies suggest a positive impact of secure attachment, holistic thinking style, and trait empathy on consumer forgiveness (Alnawas et al., 2023; Salagrama et al., 2021). Conversely, anxious attachment, analytical thinking, need for closure, and high construal levels are negatively associated with consumer forgiveness owing to the same rationale (Alnawas et al., 2023; Çelik et al., 2024; Hassey, 2019). Concerning reducing the use of affective information in the thinking process, researchers identify the positive effects of emotional intelligence, decision involvement, and cultural happiness on consumer forgiveness (Cheng, 2023; Papadopoulou et al., 2023; Tsarenko et al., 2019). These assumptions are aligned with the suggestions of coping theory and the interpersonal forgiveness literature (Lazarus & Folkman, 1984; McCullough et al., 1997). However, it is noteworthy to mention that we have not witnessed any direct application regarding the moderation role of how consumers' chronic coping styles despite the coping theory being the most applied theoretical framework in the literature.

The brand-related variables associated with this theme are primarily examined under the theoretical accounts of social identity and in-group favoritism (Tajfel & Turner, 1979). Empirical studies suggest consumers can be more forgiving of the transgressions made by home brands (Ge et al., 2023; Zourrig et al., 2015), peer-based service providers (Rathee et al., 2022), and underdog brands (Septianto et al., 2020), compared to their counterparts. However, evidence also suggests that these positive characteristics could also lead to unforgiveness, referred to as the "origin-backfire" effect, which occurs when consumers perceive threats and betrayals from transgressions committed by home brands (Davvetas et al., 2024). Some of the plausible underlying mechanisms explaining these contrasting findings are identified in the literature. Specifically, consumers can exhibit a lower tolerance for transgressions from home brands if they are idiocentric (Zourrig et al., 2015) or if they are from a loose culture (Ge et al., 2023). In the category of relationship-related variables, we find that most of the relationship-based measures, such as brand attachment (Flacandji et al., 2023), brand commitment (Lin & Chou, 2022), brand interaction frequency (Kuchmaner et al., 2024), parasocial relationship (Aw et al., 2022), relationship length (Chen et al., 2022c; Lin & Chou, 2022) play a positive role in consumer forgiveness. However, Wolter et al. (2019) find an exception: this buffering effect can backfire when consumers develop a sense of entitlement from their relationship with the brand.

TABLE 4 Mediating variables investigated in the consumer forgiveness literature.

Stage	Variable	Theory	Studies
Primary	Perceived severity	Attribution theory	Alnawas et al. (2023); Fetscherin & Sampedro (2019); Ge et al. (2023); Harrison-Walker (2022); Hassey (2019); Hur & Jang (2019); Joireman et al. (2016); Riaz & Khan (2016); Sahaf & Fazili (2024); Salagrama et al. (2021); Tsarenko & Tojib (2012); Tsarenko & Tojib (2015)
	Responsibility attribution (internal vs. external)		Arikan et al. (2023); Chen et al. (2022b); 2022c; Cheng (2023); Zourrig et al. (2015)
	Perceived controllability		Lin & Chou (2022); Salagrama et al. (2021)
	Stability		Lin & Chou (2022); Salagrama et al. (2021)
	Perceived intent	Cognitive appraisal theory	Harrison-Walker (2022)
	Threat appraisal		Davvetas et al. (2024)
	Harm/loss appraisal		Harrison-Walker (2022); Zourrig et al. (2009)
	Negative moral evaluation	Moral psychology	Davvetas et al. (2024); Li et al. (2022); Rathee et al. (2022)
Secondary	Perceived distributive justice	Justice theory	Muhammad & Gul-e-Rana (2019); Siamagka (2023)
	Perceived interactional justice		Muhammad & Gul-e-Rana (2019); Siamagka (2023)
	Perceived procedural justice		Muhammad & Mokhtar (2017); Muhammad & Gul-e-Rana (2019); Siamagka (2023)
	Perceived justice (as a whole)	Trust theory	Septianto et al. (2020)
	Perceived integrity		Agnihotri & Bhattacharya (2024); Noor et al. (2023); Xie & Peng (2009)
	Perceived competence		Agnihotri & Bhattacharya (2024); Noor et al. (2023); Xie & Peng (2009)
	Perceived benevolence		Agnihotri & Bhattacharya (2024); Xie & Peng (2009)
Hybrid	Emotion of fear	Coping theory	Ran et al. (2016)
	Emotion of anger		Atav et al. (2021); Çelik et al., 2024; Ran et al. (2016); Riaz & Khan (2016)
	Emotion of empathy	Interpersonal forgiveness literature	Chen et al. (2022b); Suri et al. (2019)
	Emotion of sympathy		Atav et al. (2021); Zourrig et al. (2015)
	Emotion of compassion		Riaz & Khan (2016)

3.4.2.2 | Theme 2: Effective recovery

There are 15 studies that compared the effectiveness of different transgression recovery strategies (e.g., apology vs. compensation), while exploring their boundary conditions. We find three core research streams: *apology versus compensation* (Aw et al., 2022; Casidy & Shin, 2015; Najam, 2022; Shin et al., 2018; Shuqair et al., 2021; Wei et al., 2020), *the use of justification* (Chen et al., 2022b; Tsarenko & Tojib, 2015), and *other recovery fit* (Atav et al., 2021; Ran et al., 2016; Wei & Ran, 2019) based on the nature of the research investigations.

Apology versus compensation. Empirical evidence suggests that the nature of the transgression and consumer traits determine the decision to use an apology or compensation in service recovery. Studies suggest the use of apology is more contingent on the

contexts, such as when the transgression is indirect to consumers (Casidy & Shin, 2015; Shin et al., 2018), when consumers perceive a communal relationship with the brand (Shuqair et al., 2021), when consumers have interdependent (vs. independent) self-construal (Aw et al., 2022), when consumers have an agreeable (vs. conscientious) personality (Najam, 2022), and when consumers perceive high power against the brand (Wei et al., 2020). In contrast, compensation is found to be an effective tool for achieving consumer forgiveness across most contexts, except for cases involving indirect transgressions and high-power consumers (Casidy & Shin, 2015; Shin et al., 2018; Wei et al., 2020).

The use of justification. This line of research emphasizes a crucial objective in the recovery process: the incorporation of justification in recovery efforts to mitigate potential liabilities (Coombs

et al., 2010; You et al., 2020). Two pioneering studies explored the relationship between the use of apology, the embedment of justification or defense within an apology (Hearit, 1995), and consumer forgiveness. Tsarenko and Tojib (2015) discovered that apology is an effective tactic when consumers perceive the transgression as mild and when the previous corporate social responsibility (CSR) activities of the brand are unknown. Chen et al. (2022b) suggest that apology is effective when the transgression is perceived as uncontrollable and when consumers hold a fresh-start mindset, the belief that people can make a new beginning (Price et al., 2018). As this area of research is still in its early stages and offers valuable practical implications, we encourage future researchers to investigate additional conditions that support the use of apology and to compare different strategies for delivering it in recovery scenarios.

Other recovery fit. Extant literature also suggests other types of recovery fit. Two studies apply the regulatory fit theory and demonstrate that a fit between consumers' mental state and the recovery message framing can lead to a better outcome for consumer forgiveness (Higgins, 2005). More specifically, Atav et al. (2021) find congruence between consumers' temporary regulatory focus and the recovery message-framing can increase the likelihood of consumer forgiveness. Informed by the same rationale, Ran et al. (2016) identify a match between consumers' elicited emotions (fear vs. anger) and the recovery message framing (shame vs. guilt) can have a similar effect. As to the effect of gender, Wei and Ran (2019) also identify a match between the apologizer's gender (male vs. female) and transgression type (performance vs. value-based) can increase consumer forgiveness.

3.4.2.3 | Further synthesis with the qualitative findings

Two qualitative studies provide valuable insights into the moderating roles of consumer-brand relationships (Finsterwalder et al., 2017) and consumer emotional intelligence (Mednini & Damak Turki, 2024) in the context of consumer forgiveness, complementing existing quantitative investigations. Notably, Casey et al. (2024) highlight the significance of social climates in shaping consumer forgiveness. Their research demonstrates that consumers tend to engage with online brand communities when confronted with negative marketing events, utilizing these platforms to gather essential information for their attribution processes and to express their negative emotions. Consequently, the collective opinions and sentiments shared within these communities play a pivotal role in shaping consumers' forgiveness journeys as subsequent consumers may adopt prevailing narratives to assess the severity of the incident and the brand's responsibility. Furthermore, the dominant sentiments within online brand communities can create a contagion effect, significantly informing consumers' emotional states throughout their forgiveness processes. Given the prevalence of online communities and social media, we recommend that future studies explore the effects of social climates on consumer forgiveness further. Table 5 summarizes the moderation variables examined in the literature.

4 | RESULTS

4.1 | The proposed consumer forgiveness as a coping process

Our aim in conducting this detailed literature review is to build a comprehensive conceptual framework to explain the consumer forgiveness process. The synthesis outlined in the previous sections have informed our theory-driven integrative framework delineating salient psychological mechanisms of the consumer forgiveness process. In this section we introduce and explain this proposed framework. This framework also responds to the call for research by Kim et al. (2023) for an integrated theoretical framework to aid marketing researchers in explaining and understanding consumer forgiveness. We use the coping literature as the backbone of our framework and argue that forgiveness is a coping mechanism that consumers take to free themselves from the negative impacts of a negative marketing event. From this perspective, the overarching goal of forgiveness is to remove the present negative emotional arousal and to control future similar harms, losses, or threats to consumer self-concepts (Lazarus & Folkman, 1984). The length of consumers' coping processes and the coping approach consumers use (e.g., forgiveness, avoidance) are subjective to the extent that the core objectives are achieved, at least under consumers' coping abilities (Epstein & Katz, 1992). Additionally, we integrate the theoretical arguments from the attribution, coping, justice, and trust theories to capture the cognitive activities within the two appraisal stages in the consumer forgiveness process (see Figure 3). Core mediation and moderation variables in our proposed consumer forgiveness process are consolidated with the empirical studies in the literature.

We argue that the consumer forgiveness process entails cognitive, emotional, and motivational components. At the first step, the consumer forgiveness process begins when a stressor (or transgressor) induces distress for the consumer and damages the consumer-stressor relationship. At the primary appraisal stage, we suggest that consumers engage in harm evaluation and harm attribution. As attribution theory indicates, upon facing a stressor, the consumer appraises the severity, direction, intent, stability, and controllability of the harm inflicted. If the harm is deemed insufficiently impactful, the consumer may not exhibit negative reactions, rendering forgiveness unnecessary. Intent, stability, and controllability are indicative of predicting how consumers attribute the responsibility of the transgression to the transgressor. The lower the perceived responsibility, the higher the likelihood that consumers would forgive the transgression. Additionally, for the forgiveness process to initiate, consumers need to have the motivation to forgive, otherwise they will not pay attention to the recovery efforts by the transgressor.

In the secondary appraisal stage, a concerted effort by the transgressing brand to facilitate recovery is imperative. Several different attempts by the stressor to recuperate a harmed relationship have been studied by marketing scholars. These recovery efforts include apologizing for the negative marketing event, compensating the consumer for the harm done, taking actions to prevent future

TABLE 5 Moderating variables investigated in the consumer forgiveness literature.

Category	Variable	Theme	Studies
Brand	Brand authenticity	Transgression tolerance	Papadopoulou et al. (2023)
	Brand personality (fun)	Transgression tolerance	Rathee et al. (2022)
	Brand personality (warmth vs. competence)	Transgression tolerance	Hassey (2019)
	Brand reputation	Transgression tolerance	Li et al. (2022), Noor et al. (2023)
	Brand reputation	Effective recovery	Tsarenko & Tojib (2015)
	Brand type (communal vs. functional)	Transgression tolerance	Hassey (2019)
	Brand type (in-group vs. out-group)	Transgression tolerance	Davvetas et al. (2024); Ge et al. (2023); Septianto et al. (2020); Zourrig et al. (2015)
	Brand type (peer-based vs. conventional)	Transgression tolerance	Shuqair et al. (2021); Suri et al. (2019)
	Brand type (public vs. private)	Transgression tolerance	Noor et al. (2023)
Consumer	Attachment style (secure vs. anxious)	Transgression tolerance	Alnawas et al. (2023)
	Construal level	Transgression tolerance	Çelik et al., 2024
	Perceived power	Effective recovery	Wei et al. (2020)
	Cultural happiness	Transgression tolerance	Papadopoulou et al. (2023)
	Culture (tight vs. loose)	Transgression tolerance	Ge et al. (2023)
	Decision-making involvement	Transgression tolerance	Cheng (2023)
	Emotional intelligence	Transgression tolerance	Tsarenko & Tojib (2012)
	Ethnocentrism	Transgression tolerance	Davvetas et al. (2024)
	Gender	Transgression tolerance	Hur & Jang (2019)
	Gender	Effective recovery	Yagil & Luria (2016)
	Need for closure	Transgression tolerance	Hassey (2019)
	Patriotism	Transgression tolerance	Li et al. (2022)
	Personality (agreeableness vs. conscientiousness)	Effective recovery	Ran et al. (2016)
	Personality (allocentric vs. idiocentric)	Transgression tolerance	Zourrig et al. (2015)
	Perspective (observer vs. victim)	Effective recovery	Shin et al. (2018)
	Regulatory fit	Effective recovery	Atav et al. (2021); Ran et al. (2016)
	Religiosity	Effective recovery	Shimul et al. (2022)
	Self-construal	Effective recovery	Aw et al. (2022); Luo et al. (2024)
	Self-construal	Transgression tolerance	Sinha & Lu (2016)
	Starter mindset	Transgression tolerance	Chen et al. (2022b)
	Technology readiness	Effective recovery	Guan & Sun (2023)
	Thinking style (holistic vs. analytical)	Transgression tolerance	Alnawas et al. (2023)
	Trait empathy	Transgression tolerance	Salagrama et al. (2021)
	Trait narcissism	Transgression tolerance	Siamagka (2023)
Relationship	Brand attachment	Transgression tolerance	Flacandji et al. (2023)
	Brand commitment	Transgression tolerance	Lin & Chou (2022)
	Brand interaction frequency	Transgression tolerance	Kuchmaner et al. (2024)
	Parasocial relationship	Transgression tolerance	Aw & Labrecque (2023)
	Relationship length	Transgression tolerance	Chen et al. (2022c); Lin & Chou (2022)

TABLE 5 (Continued)

Category	Variable	Theme	Studies
	Relationship norms (communal vs. exchange)	Transgression tolerance	Cheng (2023)
	Relationship strength	Transgression tolerance	Christodoulides et al. (2021); Sinha & Lu (2016)
	Relationship strength	Effective recovery	Yagil & Luria (2016)
	Relationship-value dependence	Transgression tolerance	Chen et al. (2022c)
	Switch-cost dependence	Transgression tolerance	Chen et al. (2022c)
Recovery Strategies	Apologizer gender (male vs. female)	Effective recovery	Wei & Ran (2019)
	Apology framing strategy (guilt vs. shame)	Effective recovery	Ran et al. (2016)
	Recovery strategies (apology vs. deny)	Effective recovery	Shimul et al. (2022)
	Recovery strategies (apology vs. apologia)	Effective recovery	Tsarenko & Tojib (2015)
	Recovery Strategies (apology vs. compensation)	Effective recovery	Casidy & Shin (2015); Najam (2022); Shin et al. (2018); Shuqair et al. (2021); Wei et al. (2020)
	Recovery Strategies (defensive, accommodating vs. reticent)	Effective recovery	Chen et al. (2022b)
	Recovery sentiment (warmth vs. task vs. coldness oriented)	Effective recovery	Luo et al. (2024)

harm, and/or providing a justification for the reasons behind the transgression. Guided by justice theory, we introduce the constructs of interactional, distributional, and procedural justice at this stage. Consumers evaluate recovery effectiveness with the extent to which they agree that interactional, distributive and/or procedural justice have been restored. Perceived justice predicts the likelihood that consumers can disassociate themselves from the stressors, namely the removal of the negative emotional state, the controllability of future similar harm, and the removal of threats to consumers' self-images (Blodgett et al., 1997; Lazarus & Folkman, 1984; Skarlicki & Folger, 1997). Consumers are likely to deploy forgiveness as their coping strategy when they perceive the source of the harm cease to exist. This may mean the perishment of the stressor or no likelihood of the transgression to reoccur. Consumers then will let go of the negative emotions, cognition and behavior and keep their patronage and connections with the brand.

In sum, we propose that consumer forgiveness is an emotional, cognitive, and behavioral journey where consumers (1) acknowledge harmful behavior by stressor, (2) assess and perceive stressor as harmful, (3) acknowledge recovery efforts by stressor, (4) assess and perceive recovery efforts as effective, and (5) at the bare minimum let go of negative emotions, cognitions and behavior that is stimulated by stressor.

Lastly, it is important to underline that consumer forgiveness and unforgiveness are distinct outcomes of the same process. Consumer forgiveness occurs when customers are satisfied with a company's recovery and trust repair efforts during the secondary appraisal stage. If these efforts are deemed unsatisfactory, forgiveness will not occur. When forgiveness is not achieved, retaliation may result, as

consumers perceive the firm's actions as harmful and wrong, attributing blame to the company (Aquino et al., 2001; Beugré, 2005; Funches et al., 2009). Consumers who view recovery efforts as unsuccessful may choose retaliation as their coping strategy. This can involve behaviors such as brand switching, boycotting, or spreading negative word-of-mouth (Duhachek & Oakley, 2007; Worthington & Scherer, 2004). Retaliation, triggered by cognitive thoughts of harm, involves actions taken in response to an offense, often fueled by rage and anger (Allred, 1999). Revenge, a form of retaliation, involves aggressive behavior (Spencer, 1892).

Another type of consumer unforgiveness is brand avoidance, where consumers opt not to engage in aggressive retaliatory actions but instead disengage from the brand. Brand avoidance occurs when consumers deliberately distance themselves from a brand to avoid negative experiences or associations (Lee et al., 2009). Similar to retaliation, avoidance also requires that customers are unsatisfied with a company's recovery and trust repair efforts during the secondary appraisal stage. Unlike retaliation, which involves overt negative behaviors, brand avoidance is a passive coping strategy where the consumer simply chooses not to engage with the offending brand. Brand avoidance highlights a less confrontational but equally damaging form of consumer unforgiveness, as it leads to long-term disengagement and loss of customer loyalty.

To the best of our knowledge, our consumer forgiveness process is the first holistic theoretical framework that integrates all conceptual, qualitative, and quantitative work in literature. Our framework consolidates the fragmented literature and provides a roadmap for future researchers about the core cognitive, emotional, and motivational components of the consumer forgiveness process.

5 | FUTURE RESEARCH AGENDA

After a comprehensive synthesis of the literature, we identify six key avenues for future research, encompassing a total of 14 emerging research questions. These research agendas highlight critical gaps in the existing body of knowledge across three major areas: service recovery (incorporating justification), information processing (the roles of self-concept maintenance, coping styles and emotions), as well as the contexts of AI and social climates.

5.1 | Avenue 1: Further investigation of when and how to incorporate justification into recovery efforts to achieve consumer forgiveness

The first research avenue focuses on the secondary appraisal stage of the consumer forgiveness process, specifically examining how brands can effectively incorporate justification (e.g., an apologia) for consumer forgiveness. Embedding justification is crucial, as it can help mitigate consumers' negative emotions and reduce potential legal or financial liabilities. (Coombs et al., 2010; You et al., 2020). Two pioneering studies demonstrate that this approach can effectively foster consumer forgiveness when dealing with uncontrollable failures and addressing consumers with a fresh-start mindset (Chen et al., 2022b; Tsarenko & Tojib, 2015). Given that this research area is still in its early stages, we recommend future researchers investigate the question *"What other contexts also support the incorporation of justification into recovery efforts to achieve consumer forgiveness?"*

Additionally, the optimal methods for incorporating justification remain largely underexplored in the consumer forgiveness literature. Theoretical frameworks from the field of communication may offer foundational insights for further scholarly inquiry. For instance, future research could examine the effectiveness of various justification tactics, such as differentiation and transcendence, in fostering consumer forgiveness (Benoit, 1995). Therefore, we also recommend that future scholars investigate the question, *"What strategies can marketers implement to effectively incorporate justification into recovery efforts to achieve consumer forgiveness?"*

5.2 | Avenue 2: Further investigation of the role of self-concept maintenance in consumer forgiveness

The second research avenue also centers on the secondary appraisal stage of the consumer forgiveness process with respect to the role of self-concept maintenance behind consumer forgiveness. While existing empirical studies have primarily examined the impacts of justice and trust recovery—key resources that help consumers cope with negative marketing experiences—the role of self-concept maintenance remains largely overlooked. This aspect is a critical determinant of forgiveness in the interpersonal forgiveness literature (Worthington et al., 2007).

Two pioneering studies in consumer forgiveness provide a foundational basis for this exploration. Finsterwalder et al. (2017)

conducted a qualitative investigation that classified the roles of self-interest and self-protection in consumer forgiveness. Meanwhile, Tsarenko et al. (2019) highlighted further self-concept maintenance factors, such as self-healing and graceful acts.

We propose that advancing this line of inquiry could help clarify a longstanding question for marketers: why do some consumers choose to forgive while others remain unforgiving, even when they receive similar levels of justice and trust recovery? We recommend future researchers consider questions such as *"What makes forgiveness a good coping strategy for consumers?"* and *"What further self-concept maintenance-based benefits do consumers expect when choosing to forgive a brand?"*

5.3 | Avenue 3: Further investigation of the impact of consumers' coping styles on consumer forgiveness

While coping theory is the most widely applied framework in the consumer forgiveness literature, we have yet to identify any empirical investigations examining the moderating role of consumers' chronic coping styles in this context. Chronic coping styles refer to individuals' general strategies for managing stressful situations, which can include approaches like self-control and seeking social support (Folkman et al., 1986). These coping styles serve as default patterns that influence how consumers attribute the causes of stressors, evaluate the impact of those stressors on themselves, and determine potential solutions (Beverland et al., 2010).

In light of this context, we recommend that future researchers examine the role of consumers' chronic coping styles across the two appraisal stages in the forgiveness process. Specifically, researchers may explore the following questions: *"How do consumers' coping styles shape their two stages of appraisal processes?"* *"How do these styles regulate the emotional impact in the forgiveness process?"* Additionally, *"How do these styles influence consumers' motivations to forgive?"* Investigating these aspects could yield valuable insights into the intricate relationship between coping mechanisms and consumer forgiveness.

5.4 | Avenue 4: Further investigation of the role of AI in consumer forgiveness

Our fourth research avenue explores the impact of AI on consumer forgiveness across the two appraisal stages. Existing research on consumer forgiveness in the context of AI interactions is still underdeveloped, with limited studies examining how consumers forgive or fail to forgive AI-driven service failures. While consumer forgiveness has been widely explored in human-to-human and brand relationships, most AI-related literature has focused on topics like trust, acceptance, and adoption of AI technologies (Gursoy et al., 2019; Lu, 2019), leaving a significant gap in understanding the forgiveness process after AI failures. A notable exception is Robinson et al. (2020), which addresses consumer reactions to AI

service failures, but does not delve deeply into the forgiveness process. This gap is critical given the increasing reliance on AI in customer service, retail, telemedicine, and other consumer-facing industries. Studies like those from Huang and Rust (2018), Lu (2019) and Paluch and Wirtz (2020) reveal that AI alters consumer perceptions of service quality. While AI minimizes interpersonal complexities such as human error or bias, it also lacks the emotional reciprocity that often facilitates consumer forgiveness (Bitner et al., 2000; Noor et al., 2023). Therefore, particularly as the absence of human empathy and connection of AI may impact the likelihood of consumer forgiveness of AI service failures. Hence, understanding how consumers react to AI transgressions is crucial for maintaining strong consumer-brand relationships.

Future research should explore how factors unique to AI interactions—such as the perceived intentionality of AI errors, the absence of human accountability, and the lack of emotional reciprocity—influence consumer forgiveness. Additionally, there is a need to investigate how consumers' emotional, cognitive, and behavioral responses to AI failures differ from those caused by humans. Future research can address the questions *"How do consumer emotions, cognition, and behavior differ across human-caused versus AI-caused transgressions?"* and *"What type of brand recovery is more effective for AI transgressions?"*. Addressing these issues could offer critical insights into the consumer forgiveness process in AI-human interactions and help brands develop effective recovery strategies to foster consumer forgiveness and rebuild trust. As AI plays a larger role in consumer interactions, understanding these dynamics will be key to long-term success in AI-powered services.

5.5 | Avenue 5: Further investigation of the impact of social climates on consumer forgiveness

We also identify a significant gap in the research concerning the impact of social climates on consumer forgiveness across the two stages of appraisal. Apart from a qualitative study by Casey et al. (2024), there is a lack of literature exploring this critical topic. Given the widespread influence of social media, we contend that social climates are vital to understanding the consumer forgiveness journey. Specifically, when a firm or brand commits wrongdoing, it can trigger a wave of negative attention across social networking sites and online brand communities. This phenomenon, referred to as an online firestorm, presents considerable challenges for businesses due to its viral nature and the extensive reach and potential destructiveness it entails (Chan et al., 2024; Pfeffer et al., 2014).

Consequently, consumers' appraisal processes and emotional responses during the forgiveness process are likely shaped by the social climates. Given the significance of this phenomenon, we recommend that future researchers explore the following questions: *"How do social climates influence consumers' appraisal processes?"* *"In what ways do these climates amplify the emotional effects of negative experiences on the forgiveness process?"* Additionally, *how do they impact consumers' motivations to forgive?"* Investigating these aspects

could yield valuable insights into how social climate dynamics inform the consumer forgiveness process.

5.6 | Avenue 6: Further investigation of consumers' emotions in the forgiveness process

Our final proposed research avenue focuses on the role of emotions in the forgiveness process. Existing literature has examined the relationships between five key emotions—anger, fear, empathy, sympathy, and compassion—and consumers' propensity to forgive (e.g., Atav et al., 2021; Ran et al., 2016). While these emotions reflect consumers' affective evaluations during the forgiveness process, they do not fully capture the spectrum of emotional experiences involved. For instance, negative marketing events may elicit moral emotions such as disgust and *schadenfreude* rather than harm-related emotions like anger and fear (Haidt, 2003). Similarly, consumers may feel positive emotions like gratitude and thankfulness during effective service recovery rather than positive moral emotions such as empathy and compassion (Fredrickson, 2001). These understudied emotions may indicate new stressors or cognitive outcomes arising from the two stages of appraisal. Thus, we recommend that future research explore: *"What additional understudied emotions are overlooked in the literature, and how might they shape the forgiveness process?"*

More importantly, based on the appraisal-tendency framework, consumers' emotions also contain cognitive predispositions that can inform their thinking process and judgment (e.g., Lerner & Keltner, 2000). For instance, emotions such as anger and anxiety, which may arise from distinct transgressions, share a negative valence yet denote divergent motivational orientations—approach versus avoidance (Labroo & Rucker, 2010). In the realm of consumer forgiveness, the diversity of emotional experiences can lead to the adoption of various coping strategies, the allocation of cognitive resources, and the prioritization of different elements in the appraisal process. In light of this research gap, we propose that future investigations examine: *"How do consumers' emotions systematically influence their cognitive appraisal processes?"* Table 6 summarizes our proposed future research avenues and emerging research questions.

6 | DISCUSSION

Consumer forgiveness is an important part of consumer-brand relationships as many wrongdoings unfold in modern society and consumer forgiveness is an effective way of repairing consumer-brand relationships. In this paper, we try to answer calls for research that integrate theoretical understanding of consumer forgiveness behavior. We analyze and synthesize the findings of 89 articles to understand and summarize how involved agents influence the consumer forgiveness process. Based on this synthesis, we develop a theory-driven integrative framework delineating salient psychological

TABLE 6 Future research avenues and emerging research questions.

Stage	Research avenue	Emerging research questions	Literature
Secondary	Avenue 1: Further investigation of when and how to incorporate justification into recovery efforts to achieve consumer forgiveness	• What other contexts also support the incorporation of justification into recovery efforts to achieve consumer forgiveness? • What strategies can marketers implement to effectively incorporate justification into recovery efforts to achieve consumer forgiveness?	Chen et al. (2022b); Tsarenko & Tojib (2015)
Secondary	Avenue 2: Further investigation of the role of self-concept maintenance in consumer forgiveness	• What makes forgiveness a good coping strategy for consumers? • What further self-concept maintenance-based benefits do consumers expect when choosing to forgive a brand?	Finsterwalder et al., 2017; Tsarenko et al. (2019)
Primary and secondary	Avenue 3: Further investigation of the impact of consumers' coping styles on consumer forgiveness	• How do consumers' coping styles shape their two stages of appraisal processes? • How do these styles regulate the emotional impact in the forgiveness process? • How do these styles influence consumers' motivations to forgive?	-
Primary and secondary	Avenue 4: Further investigation of the role of AI in consumer forgiveness	• How do consumer emotions, cognition, and behavior differ across human-caused versus AI-caused transgressions? • What type of brand recovery is more effective for AI transgressions?	Arikan et al. (2023); Chen et al., 2022a; Cheng (2023); Lu et al. (2020)
Primary and secondary	Avenue 5: Further investigation of the impact of social climates on consumer forgiveness	• How do social climates influence consumers' appraisal processes? • In what ways do these climates amplify the emotional effects of negative experiences on the forgiveness process? • How do social climates impact consumers' motivations to forgive?	Casey et al. (2024)
Primary and secondary	Avenue 6: Further investigation of consumers' emotions in the forgiveness process	• What additional understudied emotions are overlooked in the literature, and how might they shape the forgiveness process? • How do consumers' emotions systematically influence their cognitive appraisal processes?	Atav et al. (2021); Çelik et al., 2024; Chen et al. (2022b); Ran et al. (2016); Riaz & Khan (2016); Suri et al. (2019); Zourrig et al. (2015)

mechanisms of the consumer forgiveness process. We finally propose a future research agenda on consumer forgiveness.

paper (or improve this framework) to further extend the knowledge of consumer forgiveness.

6.1 | Implications for research

Our study contributes to theory by extending the current knowledge of consumer forgiveness processes. We add to the marketing literature by providing an extensive synthesis of how involved agents influence the consumer forgiveness process. We offer a more detailed, complete, and comprehensive understanding of different stages of the consumer forgiveness process by proposing an integrative theoretical framework. Furthermore, we intend that our framework can serve as a useful guiding tool for future marketing theorists and marketers in their analysis of consumer forgiveness behavior. We welcome future consumer forgiveness studies to map their theoretical grounding onto the framework we introduce in this

6.2 | Implications for practice

Our study also provides implications for practitioners regarding achieving consumer forgiveness. First, we recommend marketing managers consider how consumers attribute the responsibility of the brand and how they appraise the transgression (e.g., loss or threat) before they decide on a crisis communication and recovery. These are the core tasks consumers undertake at the primary appraisal stage. The results will inform consumers' judgment of the transgression severity and determine the type of emotion elicited, such as anger or fear. Marketers need to consider all aspects above and ensure that their emotional and cognitive tones (e.g., Atav et al., 2021; Ran et al., 2016), their expectation of recovery strategies

(e.g., Casidy & Shin, 2015; Shin et al., 2018) meet consumers' expectations. Additionally, embedding some levels of justification or defense in the communication is possible - only when consumers perceive the transgression as mild and when they don't have any fixed expectations about the brand in the first place (Chen et al., 2022b; Tsarenko & Tojib, 2015).

As key to effective recovery, we suggest that the delivery of fairness and trustworthiness are crucial. Based on our research, these are the core elements consumers need to come to justice and conclude the consumer forgiveness process. When these conditions are met, consumers' motivations for forgiveness are higher. The perception of fairness can be delivered by ensuring consumers are treated respectfully, encouraging them to express their voices, and offering them fair recovery packages (Muhammad & Gul-E-Rana, 2020; Muhammad & Mokhtar, 2017). Consumers' trust can be repaired when brands demonstrate their ability to deliver their recovery promises, show their genuine concern about consumers' welfare, and act morally (Xie & Peng, 2009).

6.3 | Limitations and future research

We acknowledge the following limitations in our study. Firstly, we synthesize the literature published in academic journals from the core databases and overlook the sources from conference proceedings. Future work may consider further types of sources while researching this agenda. Secondly, we adopted a thematic approach to synthesize the literature. Future researchers may consider using other approaches, such as meta-analysis, to assess the robustness of findings in the consumer forgiveness literature (Paul & Barari, 2022).

CONFLICT OF INTEREST STATEMENT

The authors report that they do not have any interest or relationship, financial or otherwise, that might be perceived as influencing an author's objectivity or is considered a potential source of conflict of interest.

DATA AVAILABILITY STATEMENT

Data sharing not applicable to this article as no datasets were generated or analysed during the current study.

ORCID

Irem Yoruk  <http://orcid.org/0000-0003-0236-9023>

REFERENCES

- Aaker, J., Fournier, S., & Brasel, S. A. (2004). When good brands do bad. *Journal of Consumer Research*, 31(1), 1–16. <https://doi.org/10.1086/383419>
- Agnihotri, A., & Bhattacharya, S. (2024). Chatbots' effectiveness in service recovery. *International Journal of Information Management*, 76, 102679.
- Ali, F., El-Manstrly, D., & Abbasi, G. A. (2023). Would you forgive me? From perceived justice and complaint handling to customer forgiveness and brand credibility-symmetrical and asymmetrical perspectives. *Journal of Business Research*, 166, 114138. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jbusres.2023.114138>
- Allred, K. G. (1999). *Anger and retaliation: Toward an understanding of impassioned conflict in organizations*. Paper presented at the Research in Negotiation in Organizations, US.
- Alnawas, I., Al Khateeb, A., Abu Farha, A., & Ndubisi, N. O. (2023). The effect of service failure severity on brand forgiveness: The moderating role of interpersonal attachment styles and thinking styles. *International Journal of Contemporary Hospitality Management*, 35(5), 1691–1712. <https://doi.org/10.1108/IJCHM-03-2022-0290>
- Aquino, K., Tripp, T. M., & Bies, R. J. (2001). How employees respond to personal offense: The effects of blame attribution, victim status, and offender status on revenge and reconciliation in the workplace. *Journal of Applied Psychology*, 86(1), 52–59.
- Arikan, E., Altinigne, N., Kuzgun, E., & Okan, M. (2023). May robots be held responsible for service failure and recovery? The role of robot service provider agents' human-likeness. *Journal of Retailing and Consumer Services*, 70, 103175. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jretconser.2022.103175>
- Atav, G., Chatterjee, S., & Roy, R. (2021). To forgive or retaliate? How regulatory fit affects emotional reactions and repurchase decisions following product failures. *Journal of Consumer Marketing*, 38(4), 397–409. <https://doi.org/10.1108/JCM-05-2020-3843>
- Aw, E. C. X., Chuah, S. H. W., Sabri, M. F., & Chong, H. X. (2022). 'We' want apology! Tailoring service recovery and self-construal to earn customer forgiveness. *International Journal of Services, Economics and Management*, 13(3), 225–242. <https://doi.org/10.1504/ijsem.2022.126216>
- Aw, E. C. X., & Labrecque, L. I. (2023). Celebrities as brand shields: The role of parasocial relationships in dampening negative consequences from brand transgressions. *Journal of Advertising*, 52(3), 387–405. <https://doi.org/10.1080/00913367.2022.2066034>
- Babin, B. J., Zhuang, W., & Borges, A. (2021). Managing service recovery experience: Effects of the forgiveness for older consumers. *Journal of Retailing and Consumer Services*, 58, 102222. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jretconser.2020.102222>
- Bath, J. K., & Bawa, A. (2020). Seeking consumer forgiveness: Face management by frontline employees. *Journal of Marketing Theory and Practice*, 28(4), 387–402. <https://doi.org/10.1080/10696679.2020.1769485>
- Baumeister, R. F., Exline, J. J., & Sommer, K. L. (1998). The victim role, grudge theory, and two dimensions of forgiveness. In E. L. J. Worthington (Ed.), *Dimensions of forgiveness: Psychological research & theological perspective*. Templeton Foundation Press.
- Benoit, W. L. (1995). *Accounts, excuses, and apologies: A theory of image restoration strategies*. State University of New York Press.
- Beugré, C. D. (2005). Understanding injustice-related aggression in organizations: A cognitive model. *The International Journal of Human Resource Management*, 16(7), 1120–1136.
- Beverland, M. B., Kates, S. M., Lindgreen, A., & Chung, E. (2010). Exploring consumer conflict management in service encounters. *Journal of the Academy of Marketing Science*, 38, 617–633.
- Bitner, M. J., Brown, S. W., & Meuter, M. L. (2000). Technology infusion in service encounters. *Journal of the Academy of Marketing Science*, 28(1), 138–149.
- Blodgett, J. G., Hill, D. J., & Tax, S. S. (1997). The effects of distributive, procedural, and interactional justice on postcomplaint behavior. *Journal of Retailing*, 73(2), 185–210. [https://doi.org/10.1016/S0022-4359\(97\)90003-8](https://doi.org/10.1016/S0022-4359(97)90003-8)
- Casey, J., Huang, Y., & Chen, S. (2024). Consumer response journey following a product-harm crisis: The role of online brand communities. *Journal of Consumer Behaviour*, 23(2), 855–874. <https://doi.org/10.1002/cb.2254>
- Casidy, R., & Shin, H. (2015). The effects of harm directions and service recovery strategies on customer forgiveness and negative word-of-mouth intentions. *Journal of Retailing and Consumer Services*, 27, 103–112. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jretconser.2015.07.012>
- Çelik, S., Özkan Tektaş, Ö., & Kavak, B. (2024). The effect of service recovery on socially distant third-party customers: An experimental

- research on emotions, forgiveness, repatronage intention and WoM. *Journal of Service Theory and Practice*, 34, 519–542. <https://doi.org/10.1108/JSTP-09-2023-0267>
- Chan, T. K., Cheung, C. M., & Lee, Z. W. (2017). The state of online impulse-buying research: A literature analysis. *Information & Management*, 54(2), 204–217.
- Chan, T. K. H., Lee, Z. W. Y., Skoumpopoulou, D., & Situmeang, F. (2024). Judging the wrongness of firms in social media firestorms: The heuristic and systematic information processing perspective. *Journal of the Association for Information Systems*, 25(2), 463–500. <https://doi.org/10.17705/1jais.00837>
- Chen, A., Pan, Y., Li, L., & Yu, Y. (2022a). Are you willing to forgive AI? Service recovery from medical AI service failure. *Industrial Management and Data Systems*, 122(11), 2540–2557. <https://doi.org/10.1108/IMDS-12-2021-0801>
- Chen, S., Ran, Y., & Xiong, J. (2022b). Rise from the ashes or repeat the past? The effects of fresh start mindset and brand crisis type on consumer forgiveness. *Nankai Business Review International*, 13(4), 497–516. <https://doi.org/10.1108/NBRI-07-2021-0049>
- Chen, X., Guo, S., Xiong, J., & Hao, S. (2022c). Approach with initiative or hold on passively? The impact of customer-perceived dependence on customer forgiveness in service failure. *Frontiers in Psychology*, 13, 914024. <https://doi.org/10.3389/fpsyg.2022.914024>
- Cheng, L. K. (2023). Effects of service robots' anthropomorphism on consumers' attribution toward and forgiveness of service failure. *Journal of Consumer Behaviour*, 22(1), 67–81. <https://doi.org/10.1002/cb.2112>
- Chong, Y. S., & Ahmed, P. K. (2018). When service failure leads to sin: Exploring service transgression and customer forgiveness in a multi-faith context. *Journal of Service Theory and Practice*, 28(4), 410–433. <https://doi.org/10.1108/JSTP-02-2017-0024>
- Christodoulides, G., Gerrath, M. H. E. E., & Siamagka, N. T. (2021). Don't be rude! The effect of content moderation on consumer-brand forgiveness. *Psychology & Marketing*, 38(10), 1686–1699. <https://doi.org/10.1002/mar.21458>
- Coombs, T. W., Frandsen, F., Holladay, S. J., & Johansen, W. (2010). Why a concern for apology and crisis communication? *Corporate Communications. An International Journal*, 15(4), 337–349.
- Davvetas, V., Ulqinaku, A., & Katsikeas, C. S. (2024). Brand transgressions: How, when, and why home country bias backfires. *Journal of the Academy of Marketing Science*, 52, 976–997. <https://doi.org/10.1007/s11747-024-01018-9>
- Dawar, N., & Pillutla, M. M. (2000). Impact of product-harm crises on brand equity: The moderating role of consumer expectations. *Journal of Marketing Research*, 37(2), 215–226. <https://doi.org/10.1509/jmkr.37.2.215.18729>
- Dlodlo, N. (2017). A second chance to serve South African private banking consumers: The role of post-transgression forgiveness. *Banks and Bank Systems*, 12(3), 166–178. [https://doi.org/10.21511/bbs.12\(3-1\).2017.02](https://doi.org/10.21511/bbs.12(3-1).2017.02)
- Duhachek, A., & Oakley, J. L. (2007). Mapping the hierarchical structure of coping: Unifying empirical and theoretical perspectives. *Journal of Consumer Psychology*, 17(3), 216–233. [https://doi.org/10.1016/S1057-7408\(07\)70030-X](https://doi.org/10.1016/S1057-7408(07)70030-X)
- Enright, R. D., Freedman, S., & Rique, J. (1998). The psychology of interpersonal forgiveness. In *Exploring forgiveness* (pp. 46–62). University of Wisconsin Press.
- Epstein, S., & Katz, L. (1992). Coping ability, stress, productive load, and symptoms. *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology*, 62(5), 813–825. <https://doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.62.5.813>
- Fedorikhin, A., Park, C. W., & Thomson, M. (2008). Beyond fit and attitude: The effect of emotional attachment on consumer responses to brand extensions. *Journal of Consumer Psychology*, 18(4), 281–291. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jcps.2008.09.006>
- Fetscherin, M., & Sampedro, A. (2019). Brand forgiveness. *Journal of Product & Brand Management*, 28(5), 633–652. <https://doi.org/10.1108/JPBM-04-2018-1845>
- Finkel, E. J., Rusbult, C. E., Kumashiro, M., & Hannon, P. A. (2002). Dealing with betrayal in close relationships: Does commitment promote forgiveness? *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology*, 82(6), 956–974. <https://doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.82.6.956>
- Finsterwalder, J., Yee, T., & Tombs, A. (2017). Would you forgive kristen stewart or tiger woods or maybe lance armstrong? Exploring consumers' forgiveness of celebrities' transgressions. *Journal of Marketing Management*, 33(13–14), 1204–1229. <https://doi.org/10.1080/0267257X.2017.1382553>
- Flacandji, M., Cusin, J., & Lunardo, R. (2023). When and why signaling frontline employee inexperience can prove to be an asset: Effects on consumer forgiveness for service failure. *Psychology & Marketing*, 40(12), 2728–2742. <https://doi.org/10.1002/mar.21897>
- Folkman, S., Lazarus, R. S., Dunkel-Schetter, C., DeLongis, A., & Gruen, R. J. (1986). Dynamics of a stressful encounter: Cognitive appraisal, coping, and encounter outcomes. *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology*, 50(5), 992–1003.
- Fredrickson, B. L. (2001). The role of positive emotions in positive psychology: The broaden-and-build theory of positive emotions. *American Psychologist*, 56(3), 218–226.
- Funches, V., Markley, M., & Davis, L. (2009). Reprisal, retribution and requital: Investigating customer retaliation. *Journal of Business Research*, 62(2), 231–238. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jbusres.2008.01.030>
- Ge, J., Jo, M. S., & Sarigollu, E. (2023). How does cultural tightness-looseness affect attitudes toward a local vs foreign brand transgression? *International Marketing Review*, 40(6), 1456–1479. <https://doi.org/10.1108/IMR-06-2022-0151>
- Greenberg, J. (1990). Organizational justice: Yesterday, today, and tomorrow. *Journal of Management*, 16(2), 399–432.
- Guan, H., & Sun, X. (2023). Research on the service remediation mechanism of e-commerce chatbots empathic response on consumers forgiveness intention. *International Journal of Innovative Computing, Information and Control*, 19(5), 1573–1591. <https://doi.org/10.24507/ijicic.19.05.1573>
- Gursoy, D., Chi, O. H., Lu, L., & Nunkoo, R. (2019). Consumers acceptance of artificially intelligent (AI) device use in service delivery. *International Journal of Information Management*, 49, 157–169.
- Haidt, J. (2003). The moral emotions. *Handbook of affective sciences*, (pp. 852–870). Oxford University Press.
- Hall, J. H., & Fincham, F. D. (2005). Self-forgiveness: The stepchild of forgiveness research. *Journal of Social and Clinical Psychology*, 24(5), 621–637. <https://doi.org/10.1521/jscp.2005.24.5.621>
- Harrison-Walker, L. J. (2019). The critical role of customer forgiveness in successful service recovery. *Journal of Business Research*, 95, 376–391. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jbusres.2018.07.049>
- Harrison-Walker, L. J. (2022). Organizational and customer moderators of service recovery on consumer forgiveness in healthcare. *Journal of Consumer Satisfaction, Dissatisfaction and Complaining Behavior*, 35, 26–51.
- Hassey, R. V. (2019). How brand personality and failure-type shape consumer forgiveness. *Journal of Product & Brand Management*, 28(2), 300–315. <https://doi.org/10.1108/JPBM-09-2017-1563>
- Hearit, K. M. (1995). "Mistakes were made": Organizations, apology, and crises of social legitimacy. *Communication Studies*, 46(1–2), 1–17.
- Higgins, E. T. (2005). Value from regulatory fit. *Current directions in psychological science*, 14(4), 209–213.
- Hook, J. N., Worthington, E. L., & Utsey, S. O. (2009). Collectivism, forgiveness, and social harmony. *The Counseling Psychologist*, 37(6), 821–847. <https://doi.org/10.1177/0011000008326546>
- Huang, M.-H., & Rust, R. T. (2018). Artificial intelligence in service. *Journal of Service Research*, 21(2), 155–172.
- Hur, J., & Jang, S. (2019). Is consumer forgiveness possible? Examining rumination and distraction in hotel service failures. *International Journal of Contemporary Hospitality Management*, 31(4), 1567–1587. <https://doi.org/10.1108/IJCHM-07-2017-0395>

- Joireman, J., Grégoire, Y., & Tripp, T. M. (2016). Customer forgiveness following service failures. *Current Opinion in Psychology*, 10, 76–82. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.copsyc.2015.11.005>
- Kaur, P., Talwar, S., Islam, N., Salo, J., & Dhir, A. (2022). The effect of the valence of forgiveness to service recovery strategies and service outcomes in food delivery apps. *Journal of Business Research*, 147, 142–157. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jbusres.2022.04.020>
- Kelley, H. H. (1973). The processes of causal attribution. *American Psychologist*, 28(2), 107–128.
- Khamitov, M., Grégoire, Y., & Suri, A. (2020). A systematic review of brand transgression, service failure recovery and product-harm crisis: Integration and guiding insights. *Journal of the Academy of Marketing Science*, 48(3), 519–542. <https://doi.org/10.1007/s11747-019-00679-1>
- Kim, C., & Kinoshita, A. (2023). Do you punish or forgive socially responsible companies? A cross-country analysis of boycott campaigns. *Journal of Retailing and Consumer Services*, 71, 103232. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jretconser.2022.103232>
- Kim, Y., Ho, T. H., Tan, L. P., & Casidy, R. (2023). Factors influencing consumer forgiveness: A systematic literature review and directions for future research. *Journal of Service Theory and Practice*, 33(5), 601–628. <https://doi.org/10.1108/JSTP-08-2022-0187>
- Kuchmaner, C. A., Wiggins, J., & Grimm, P. E. (2023). In it together: Brands benefit after a transgression when perceived as co-owners of the brand community. *Journal of Marketing Management*, 40(3–4), 1–27. <https://doi.org/10.1080/0267257X.2023.2244974>
- Labroo, A. A., & Rucker, D. D. (2010). The orientation-matching hypothesis: An emotion-specificity approach to affect regulation. *Journal of Marketing Research*, 47(5), 955–966.
- Lazarus, R. S., & Folkman, S. (1984). *Stress, appraisal, and coping*. Springer publishing company.
- Lee, M. S. W., Motion, J., & Conroy, D. (2009). Anti-consumption and brand avoidance. *Journal of Business Research*, 62(2), 169–180.
- Lerner, J. S., & Keltner, D. (2000). Beyond valence: Toward a model of emotion-specific influences on judgement and choice. *Cognition & emotion*, 14(4), 473–493.
- Li, J., Liu, L., & Qing, Q. (2022). Differentiated consumer forgiveness for different corporate social irresponsibility domains: The moderating role of corporate reputation and patriotism. *Journal of Retailing and Consumer Services*, 69, 103122. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jretconser.2022.103122>
- Lin, C. Y., & Chou, E. Y. (2022). Investigating the role of customer forgiveness following a double deviation. *Journal of Services Marketing*, 36(8), 1042–1057. <https://doi.org/10.1108/JSM-04-2021-0112>
- Lu, V. N., Wirtz, J., Kunz, W. H., Paluch, S., Gruber, T., Martins, A., & Patterson, P. G. (2020). Service robots, customers and service employees: What can we learn from the academic literature and where are the gaps? *Journal of Service Theory and Practice*, 30(3), 361–391.
- Lu, Y. (2019). Artificial intelligence: A survey on evolution, models, applications and future trends. *Journal of Management Analytics*, 6(1), 1–29.
- Luo, J., Yoo, J. E., & Park, J. E. (2024). 'From fail to prevail': How a salesperson's communication sentiment influences consumer forgiveness in service failures focusing on the role of consumer self-construal. *Journal of Global Scholars of Marketing Science*, 34(2), 231–252. <https://doi.org/10.1080/21639159.2023.2276395>
- Mayer, R. C., Davis, J. H., & Schoorman, F. D. (1995). An integrative model of organizational trust. *The Academy of Management Review*, 20(3), 709–734.
- McCullough, M. E., & Hoyt, W. T. (2002). Transgression-related motivational dispositions: Personality substrates of forgiveness and their links to the big five. *Personality and Social Psychology Bulletin*, 28(11), 1556–1573. <https://doi.org/10.1177/014616702237583>
- McCullough, M. E., Rachal, K. C., Sandage, S. J., Worthington, E. L., Brown, S. W., & Hight, T. L. (1998). Interpersonal forgiving in close relationships: II. Theoretical elaboration and measurement. *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology*, 75(6), 1586–1603. <https://doi.org/10.1037//0022-3514.75.6.1586>
- McCullough, M. E., Sandage, S. J., & Worthington, E. L. (1997). *To forgive is human: How to put your past in the past*. InterVarsity Press.
- McCullough, M. E., & Worthington, E. L. (2001). Religion and the forgiving personality. *Journal of Personality*, 67(6), 1141–1164. <https://doi.org/10.1111/1467-6494.00085>
- Mednini, L., & Damak Turki, M. (2024). How to transform brand haters into forgivers through emotional intelligence? *Management Decision*, 62(1), 183–199. <https://doi.org/10.1108/MD-06-2022-0819>
- Muhammad, H., & Mokhtar, S. S. M. (2017). Effect of procedural justice, perceived safety and forgiveness in Nigeria's domestic airline service. *International Journal of Supply Chain Management*, 6(2), 183–189.
- Muhammad, L., & Gul-E-Rana, G. (2020). Mediating role of customer forgiveness between perceived justice and satisfaction. *Journal of Retailing and Consumer Services*, 52, 101886. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jretconser.2019.101886>
- Muhammad, L., & Gul-e-Rana, G. R. (2019). Do service firm employee and customer relations matter for customer forgiveness in service recovery? *Asia Pacific Journal of Marketing and Logistics*, 31(4), 1216–1232. <https://doi.org/10.1108/APJML-09-2018-0355>
- Najam, F. (2022). Maneuvering angry consumers toward brand forgiveness and repatronage: The moderating role of personality and recovery strategies. *Lahore Journal of Business*, 10(2), 1–52. <https://doi.org/10.35536/ljb.2022.v10.i2.a1>
- Noor, M., Chao, M. M., & Doosje, B. (2023). To forgive or not to forgive an organisation: Perceived integrity versus competence transgressions shape consumers' forgiveness of transgressing organisations. *Applied Psychology*, 72(3), 1160–1180. <https://doi.org/10.1111/apps.12428>
- Özdemir, N. (2023). Systematic review on consumer forgiveness: Clarifying the domain and future research agenda. *Business & Management Studies: An International Journal (BMIJ)*, 11(3), 1241–1259. <https://doi.org/10.15295/bmij.v11i3.2294>
- Paluch, S., & Wirtz, J. (2020). Artificial intelligence and robots in the service encounter. *Journal of Service Management Research*, 4, 3–8. <https://doi.org/10.15358/2511-8676-2020-1-3>
- Papadopoulou, C., Vardarsuyu, M., & Oghazi, P. (2023). Examining the relationships between brand authenticity, perceived value, and brand forgiveness: The role of cross-cultural happiness. *Journal of Business Research*, 167, 114154. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jbusres.2023.114154>
- Paul, J., & Barari, M. (2022). Meta-analysis and traditional systematic literature reviews—what, why, when, where, and how? *Psychology & Marketing*, 39(6), 1099–1115.
- Pfeffer, J., Zorbach, T., & Carley, K. M. (2014). Understanding online firestorms: Negative word-of-mouth dynamics in social media networks. *Journal of Marketing Communications*, 20(1–2), 117–128.
- Price, L. L., Coulter, R. A., Strizhakova, Y., & Schultz, A. E. (2018). The fresh start mindset: Transforming consumers' lives. *Journal of Consumer Research*, 45(1), 21–48.
- Ran, Y., Wei, H., & Li, Q. (2016). Forgiveness from emotion fit: Emotional frame, consumer emotion, and feeling-right in consumer decision to forgive. *Frontiers in Psychology*, 7(NOV), 01775. <https://doi.org/10.3389/fpsyg.2016.01775>
- Rasouli, N., Rasoolimanesh, S. M., Rahmani, A. K., Momayez, A., & Torabi, M. A. (2022). Effects of customer forgiveness on brand betrayal and brand hate in restaurant service failures: Does apology letter matter? *Journal of Hospitality Marketing & Management*, 31(6), 662–687. <https://doi.org/10.1080/19368623.2022.2043800>
- Rathee, S., Masters, T. M., & Yu-Buck, G. F. (2022). So fun! How fun brand names affect forgiveness of hedonic and utilitarian products. *Journal of Business Research*, 139, 44–55. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jbusres.2021.09.041>

- Riaz, Z., & Khan, M. I. (2016). Impact of service failure severity and agreeableness on consumer switchover intention: Mediating role of consumer forgiveness. *Asia Pacific Journal of Marketing and Logistics*, 28(3), 420–434. <https://doi.org/10.1108/APJML-07-2015-0106>
- Robinson, S., Orsingher, C., Alkire, L., De Keyser, A., Giebelhausen, M., Papamichail, K. N., Shams, P., & Temerak, M. S. (2020). Frontline encounters of the AI kind: An evolved service encounter framework. *Journal of Business Research*, 116, 366–376.
- Rye, M. S. (1998). *Evaluation of a secular and a religiously integrated forgiveness group therapy program for college students who have been wronged by a romantic partner* [Unpublished doctoral dissertation]. Bowling Green State University.
- Sahaf, T. M., & Fazili, D. A. I. (2024). Does customer-based destination brand equity help customers forgive firm service failure in a tourist ecosystem? An investigation through explanatory sequential mixed-method design. *Journal of Destination Marketing & Management*, 31, 100866. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jdmm.2024.100866>
- Salagrama, R., Prashar, S., & Tata, S. V. (2021). Examining the influence of forgiveness and its antecedents on consumer behavior: The moderating role of service failure severity. *International Journal of Emerging Markets*, 18(10), 3973–3994. <https://doi.org/10.1108/IJOEM-11-2020-1378>
- Septianto, F., Tjiptono, F., & Kusumasondjaja, S. (2020). Anger punishes, compassion forgives: How discrete emotions mitigate double standards in consumer ethical judgment. *Journal of Retailing and Consumer Services*, 53, 101979. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jretconser.2019.101979>
- Shimul, A. S., Barber, M., & Abedin, M. I. (2022). Celebrity transgression and consumers' forgiveness: Does religiosity matter? *Journal of Islamic Marketing*, 13(6), 1224–1243. <https://doi.org/10.1108/JIMA-06-2020-0184>
- Shimul, A. S., Faroque, A. R., & Cheah, I. (2024). Does brand attachment protect consumer–brand relationships after brand misconduct in retail banking? *International Journal of Bank Marketing*, 42(2), 183–204. <https://doi.org/10.1108/IJBM-10-2022-0453>
- Shin, H., Casidy, R., & Mattila, A. S. (2018). Service recovery, justice perception, and forgiveness: The “other customers” perspectives. *Services Marketing Quarterly*, 39(1), 1–21. <https://doi.org/10.1080/15332969.2017.1398021>
- Shuqair, S., Pinto, D. C., So, K. K. F., Rita, P., & Mattila, A. S. (2021). A pathway to consumer forgiveness in the sharing economy: The role of relationship norms. *International Journal of Hospitality Management*, 98, 103041. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.ijhm.2021.103041>
- Siamagka, N. T. (2023). Explaining consumer–brand forgiveness through the lens of narcissism. *Marketing Intelligence & Planning*, 41(3), 360–374. <https://doi.org/10.1108/MIP-03-2022-0110>
- Sinha, J., & Lu, F. C. (2016). “I” value justice, but “we” value relationships: Self-construal effects on post-transgression consumer forgiveness. *Journal of Consumer Psychology*, 26(2), 265–274. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jcps.2015.06.002>
- Skarlicki, D. P., & Folger, R. (1997). Retaliation in the workplace: The roles of distributive, procedural, and interactional justice. *Journal of Applied Psychology*, 82(3), 434–443. <https://doi.org/10.1037/0021-9010.82.3.434>
- Smith, A. K., Bolton, R. N., & Wagner, J. (1999). A model of customer satisfaction with service encounters involving failure and recovery. *Journal of Marketing Research*, 36(3), 356–372. <https://doi.org/10.2307/3152082>
- Spencer, H. (1892). *The principles of ethics* Vol. 9.
- Strelan, P., & Covic, T. (2006). A review of forgiveness process models and a coping framework to guide future research. *Journal of Social and Clinical Psychology*, 25(10), 1059–1085. <https://doi.org/10.1521/jscp.2006.25.10.1059>
- Suri, A., Huang, B., & Sénécal, S. (2019). I can forgive you, but I can't forgive the firm: An examination of service failures in the sharing economy. *Journal of Marketing Theory and Practice*, 27(4), 355–370. <https://doi.org/10.1080/10696679.2019.1644958>
- Tajfel, H., & Turner, J. C. (1979). An integrative theory of intergroup conflict. In W. G. Austin, & S. Worchel (Eds.), *The social psychology of intergroup relations* (pp. 33–37). Brooks/Cole: Monterey.
- Tranfield, D., Denyer, D., & Smart, P. (2003). Towards a methodology for developing evidence-informed management knowledge by means of systematic review. *British journal of management*, 14(3), 207–222.
- Tsarenko, Y., & Rooslanij Tojib, D. (2011). A transactional model of forgiveness in the service failure context: A customer-driven approach. *Journal of Services Marketing*, 25(5), 381–392. <https://doi.org/10.1108/08876041111149739>
- Tsarenko, Y., Strizhakova, Y., & Otnes, C. C. (2019). Reclaiming the future: Understanding customer forgiveness of service transgressions. *Journal of Service Research*, 22(2), 139–155. <https://doi.org/10.1177/1094670518802060>
- Tsarenko, Y., & Tojib, D. (2012). The role of personality characteristics and service failure severity in consumer forgiveness and service outcomes. *Journal of Marketing Management*, 28(9–10), 1217–1239. <https://doi.org/10.1080/0267257X.2011.619150>
- Tsarenko, Y., & Tojib, D. (2015). Consumers' forgiveness after brand transgression: The effect of the firm's corporate social responsibility and response. *Journal of Marketing Management*, 31(17–18), 1851–1877. <https://doi.org/10.1080/0267257X.2015.1069373>
- Umar, R. M., & Saleem, S. (2022). Employee emotional competence and service recovery satisfaction: The mediating role of consumer forgiveness. *British Food Journal*, 124(13), 445–459. <https://doi.org/10.1108/BFJ-04-2022-0386>
- Van Vaerenbergh, Y., Varga, D., De Keyser, A., & Orsingher, C. (2019). The service recovery journey: Conceptualization, integration, and directions for future research. *Journal of Service Research*, 22(2), 103–119.
- Wade, S. H. (1989). *The development of a scale to measure forgiveness* [Unpublished doctoral dissertation]. Fuller Graduate School of Psychology.
- Webster, J., & Watson, R. T. (2002). Analyzing the past to prepare for the future: Writing a literature review. *MIS quarterly*, 26(2), xiii–xxiii.
- Wei, C., Liu, M. W., & Keh, H. T. (2020). The road to consumer forgiveness is paved with money or apology? The roles of empathy and power in service recovery. *Journal of Business Research*, 118, 321–334. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jbusres.2020.06.061>
- Wei, H., & Ran, Y. (2019). Male versus female: How the gender of apologizers influences consumer forgiveness. *Journal of Business Ethics*, 154(2), 371–387. <https://doi.org/10.1007/s10551-017-3440-7>
- Wei, J., Wang, Z., Hou, Z., & Meng, Y. (2022). The influence of empathy and consumer forgiveness on the service recovery effect of online shopping. *Frontiers in Psychology*, 13, 842207. <https://doi.org/10.3389/fpsyg.2022.842207>
- Weiner, B. (1985). Attribution theory, In *Human motivation* (pp. 275–326). Springer New York.
- Weiner, B. (2000). Intrapersonal and interpersonal theories of motivation from an attributional perspective. *Educational Psychology Review*, 12(1), 1–14. <https://doi.org/10.1023/A:1009017532121>
- Wolter, J. S., Bacile, T. J., Smith, J. S., & Giebelhausen, M. (2019). The entitlement/forgiveness conflict of self-relevant and self-neutral relationships during service failure and recovery. *Journal of Business Research*, 104, 233–246. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jbusres.2019.07.008>
- Worthington, Jr. E. L., & Scherer, M. (2004). Forgiveness is an emotion-focused coping strategy that can reduce health risks and promote health resilience: Theory, review, and hypotheses. *Psychology & Health*, 19(3), 385–405. <https://doi.org/10.1080/0887044042000196674>
- Worthington, Jr. E. L., Witvliet, C. V. O., Pietrini, P., & Miller, A. J. (2007). Forgiveness, health, and well-being: A review of evidence for emotional versus decisional forgiveness, dispositional forgivingness, and reduced unforgiveness. *Journal of Behavioral Medicine*, 30(4), 291–302.

- Xie, Y., & Peng, S. (2009). How to repair customer trust after negative publicity: The roles of competence, integrity, benevolence, and forgiveness. *Psychology & Marketing*, 26(7), 572–589. <https://doi.org/10.1002/mar.20289>
- Yagil, D., & Luria, G. (2016). Customer forgiveness of unsatisfactory service: Manifestations and antecedents. *Service Business*, 10, 557–579. <https://doi.org/10.1007/s11628-015-0282-1>
- Yang, Y., & Hu, J. (2021). Self-diminishing effects of awe on consumer forgiveness in service encounters. *Journal of Retailing and Consumer Services*, 60, 102491. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jretconser.2021.102491>
- You, Y., Yang, X., Wang, L., & Deng, X. (2020). When and why saying “thank you” is better than saying “sorry” in redressing service failures: The role of self-esteem. *Journal of Marketing*, 84(2), 133–150.
- Zhi, L., & Ha, H. Y. (2024). The dynamic outcomes of service recovery in tourism services: A latent growth modeling approach. *Journal of Hospitality and Tourism Management*, 59, 70–80. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jhtm.2024.03.006>
- Zourrig, H., Chebat, J. C., & Toffoli, R. (2009). Exploring cultural differences in customer forgiveness behavior. *Journal of Service Management*, 20(4), 404–419. <https://doi.org/10.1108/09564230910978502>
- Zourrig, H., Chebat, J. C., & Toffoli, R. (2015). “In-group love and out-group hate?” A cross cultural study on customers' revenge, avoidance and forgiveness behaviors. *Journal of Business Research*, 68(3), 487–499. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jbusres.2014.09.014>

How to cite this article: Yoruk, I., Hsu, J.-H., & Lee, Z. W. Y. (2024). Consumer forgiveness: A literature review and research agenda. *Psychology & Marketing*, 1–25. <https://doi.org/10.1002/mar.22138>

APPENDIX A: CONSUMER FORGIVENESS SCALES

Table A1

TABLE A1 Consumer forgiveness scales.

Xie and Peng (2009) adapted from Finkel et al. (2002)	
	1. I would think favorably of this company. 2. Given the company's response, I would condemn it. 3. Given the company's response, I would forgive it.
Tsarenko & Tojib adapted from Wade (1989) and McCullough et al. (1997)	
<i>Emotional forgiveness</i>	1. I will hold on to the hurt and anger. (R) 2. I want to see them hurt and miserable. (R) 3. I continue to think how much I hate this service provider. (R) 4. I am going to get even. (R) 5. I am not letting go of my negative emotions. (R)
<i>Decisional forgiveness</i>	6. I will continue my relationships with this service provider. 7. I will make an effort to be friendly in my future interactions with this service provider. 8. I will cut off this relationship with this service provider. (R)
Harrison-Walker (2019) adapted from Rye (1998) and McCullough et al. (2002)	
<i>Absence of forgiveness</i>	1. I can't stop thinking about how I was wronged by the service provider. (R) 2. I spend time thinking about ways to get back at the service provider who wronged me. (R) 3. I feel resentful toward the service provider who wronged me. (R) 4. I avoid certain people and/or places because they remind me of the service provider who wronged me. (R) 5. This service provider's wrongful actions have kept me from enjoying life. (R) 6. I have been able to let go of my anger toward the service provider who wronged me. 7. I become depressed when think of how I was mistreated by this service provider. (R) 8. I think that many of the emotional wounds related to this service provider's wrongful actions have healed. 9. I feel hatred whenever I think about the service provider who wronged me. (R) 10. I think my life is ruined because of this service provider's wrongful actions. (R)
<i>Presence of forgiveness</i>	11. I wish for good things to happen to the service provider who wronged me. 12. I pray for the service provider who wronged me. 13. If I encountered the service provider who wronged me, I would feel at peace. 14. I have compassion for the service provider who wronged me. 15. I hope the service provider who wronged me is treated fairly by others in the future. 16. I forgive the service provider for what he/she did to me. 17. Even though the service provider's actions hurt me, I have goodwill for him/her.
Casidy and Shin (2015) adapted from Aquino et al. (2001)	
	1) I will give the firm an opportunity to make it up to me. 2) I will make an effort to be more friendly in my future interactions with this firm. 3) I will continue my relationship with this firm.

Christodoulides et al. (2021)

Cognitive

1. I think the brand should get what it deserves. (R)
2. I wish that others could see that this brand is unworthy. (R)
3. I disapprove of this brand. (R)

Affective

4. I feel sympathetic towards this brand.
5. I have compassion for the brand, which wronged me.
6. I feel as if I have restored my faith in this brand.

Behavioral

7. I avoid using this brand. (R)
8. I do not consider this brand anymore when evaluating alternatives. (R)
9. I am less likely to try this brand again. (R)

Fedorikhin et al. (2008)

1. I would probably give the brand another chance.
2. I would probably buy the brand again despite the experience.
3. I would be less likely to try the brand again.
4. I would forgive the brand and buy it again.

Noor et al. (2023)

1. They would forgive this organization.
2. They would have any ill feelings towards this organization. (R)
3. They would hold any grudge against this organization. (R)
4. They would be resentful towards this organization.